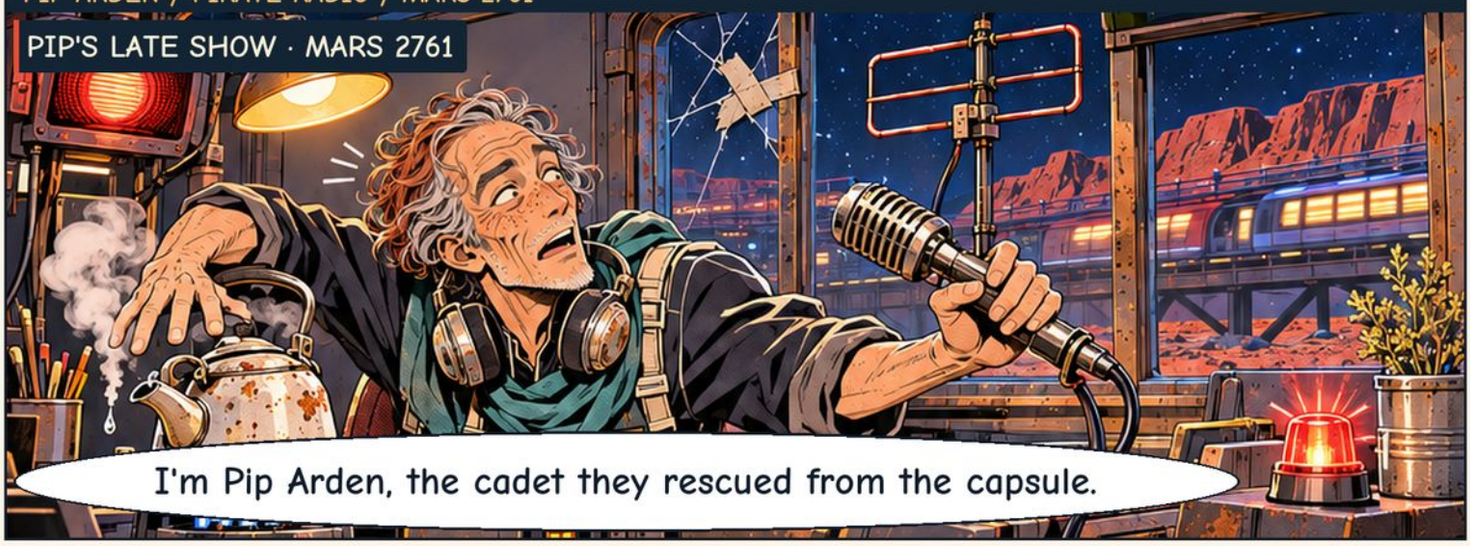
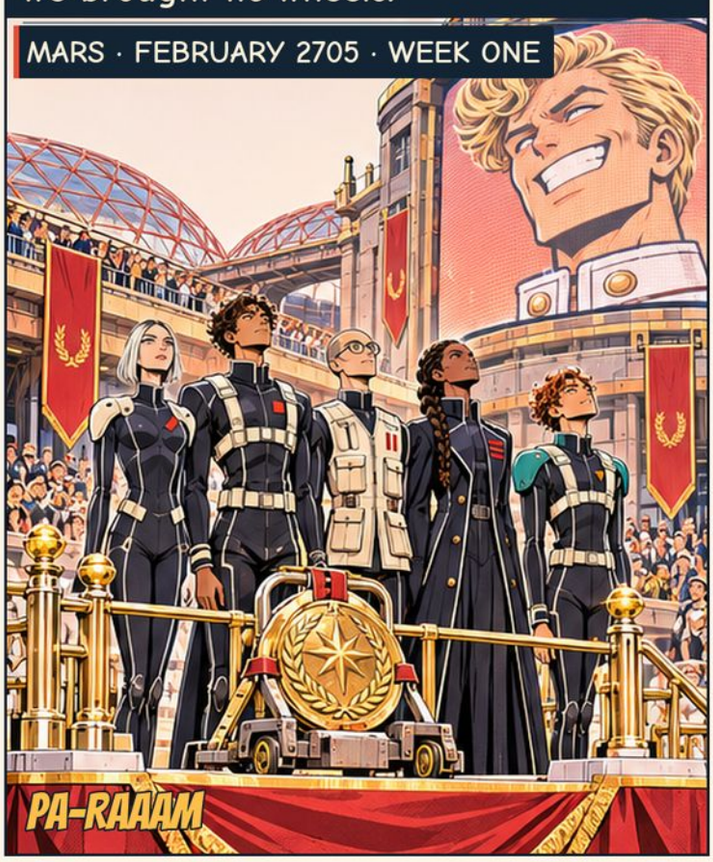
PIP ARDEN / PIRATE RADIO / MARS 2761



PIP · LATER

February 2705. The Fleet sent us on a victory tour. Rook brought the medal; we brought its wheels.



ROOK SEN

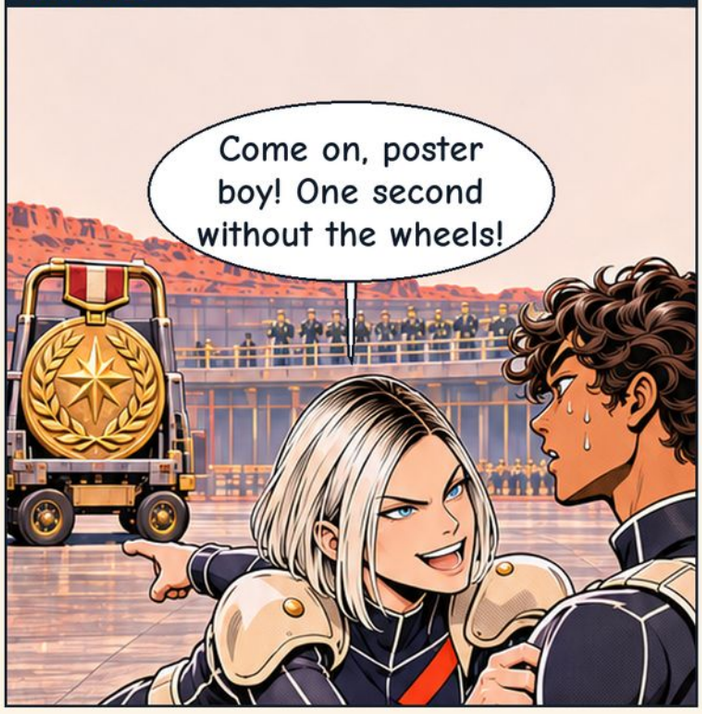
PIP · LATER

Captain Beam sold the glory. Rook was our pilot. Iona's job was catching him before the photograph.

CAPTAIN BEAM

ROOK SEN

IONA VALE

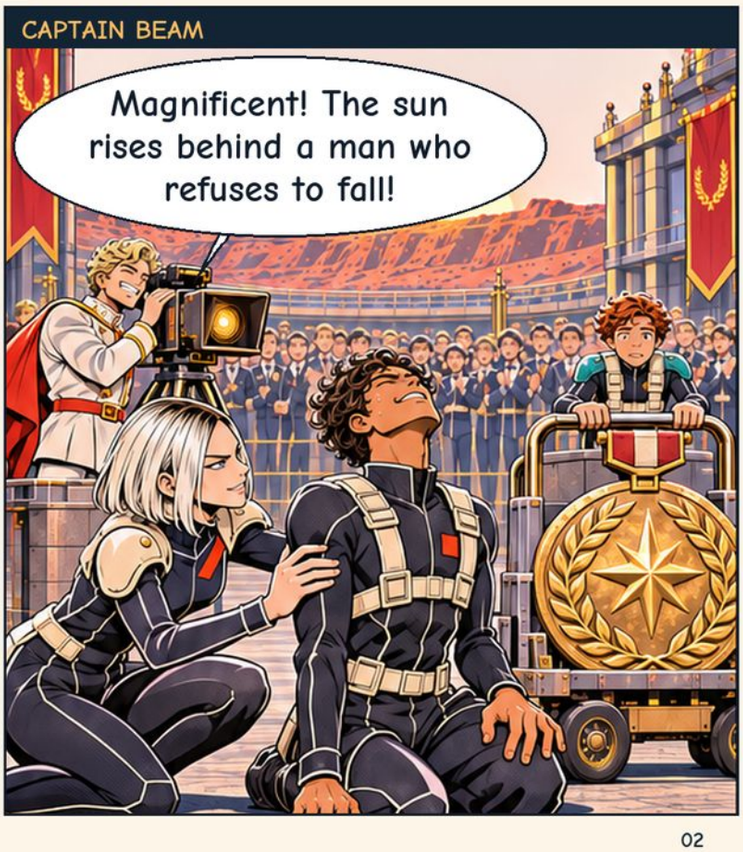


PIP · LATER

Rook could walk. His ridiculous medal couldn't. Its little trolley carried the weight until Beam asked him to pose.

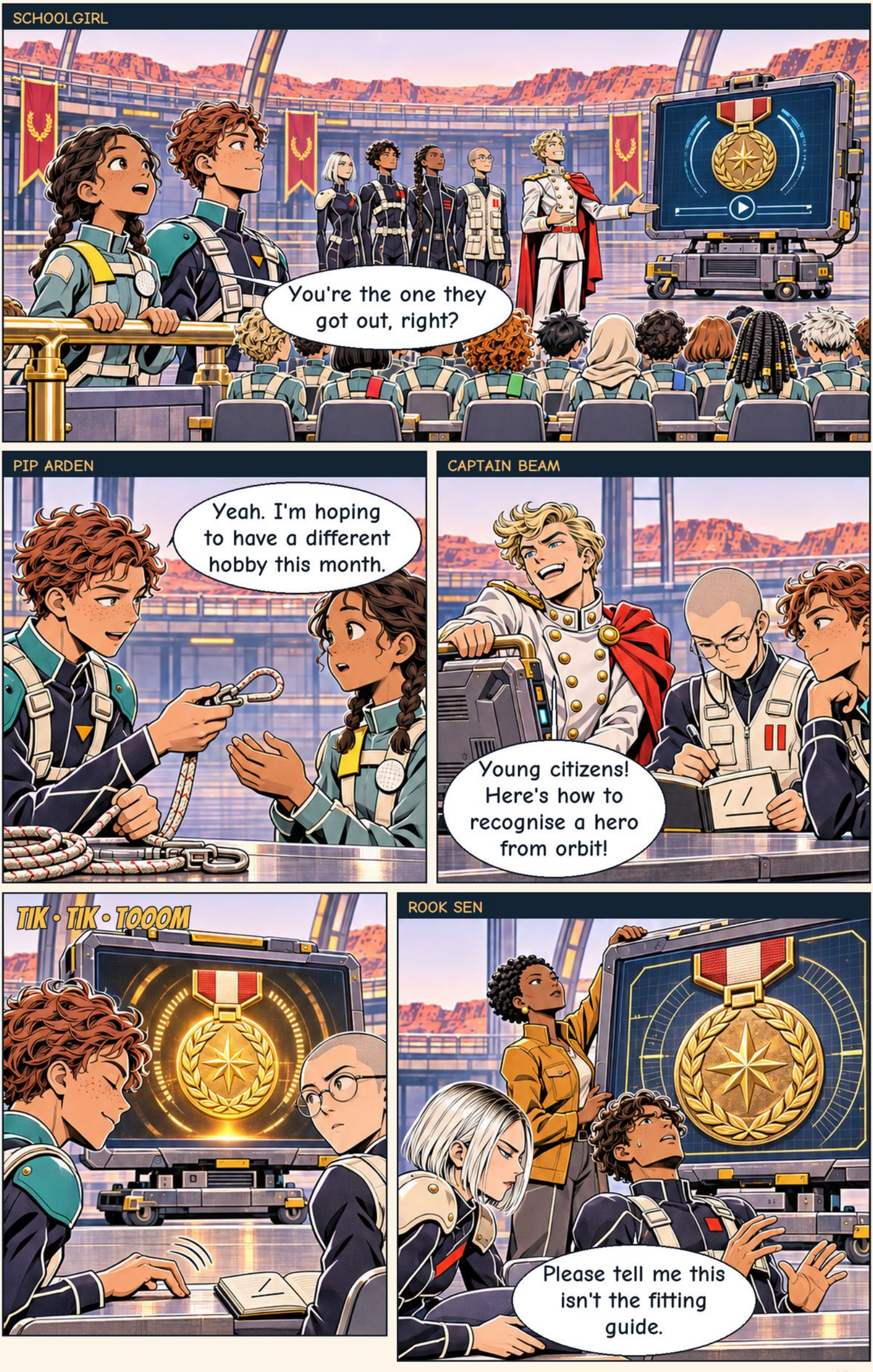
ROOK SEN

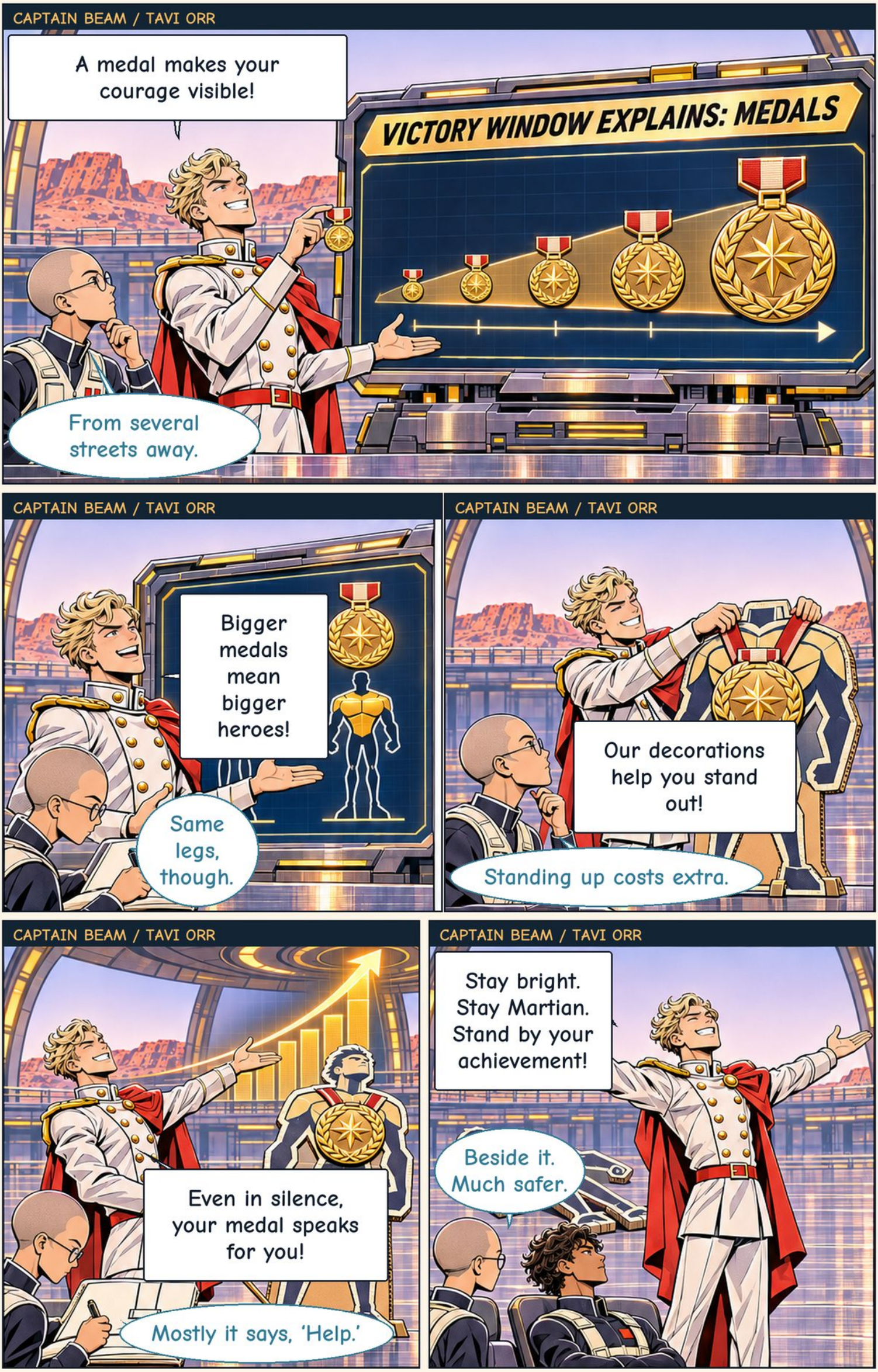
CAPTAIN BEAM

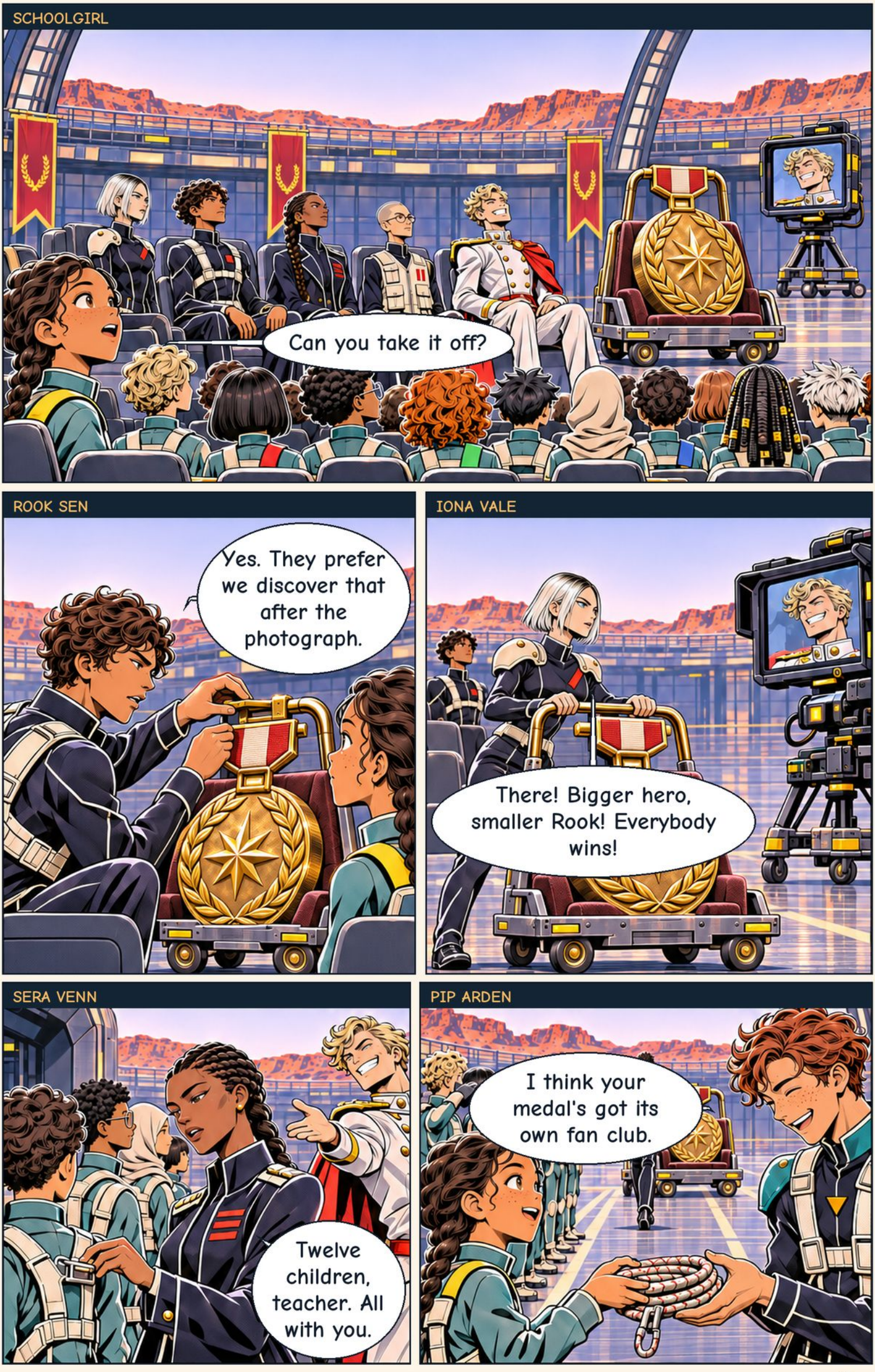


ROOK SEN
For the record, I'm taller in the finished version.
IONA VALE
Then get the finished version to carry you!
TAVI ORR
They've added leaves. The leaves are also metal.
CAPTAIN BEAM
Every leaf honours an obstacle our heroes have overcome!
SERA VENN
Carry your own foliage.

SCHOOLGIRL
THARSIS SCHOOL VISIT
Do we get one if we join?
ROOK SEN
Eventually. Start with something light. Like a spaceship.
IONA VALE
Right! Who wants to rescue him before he starts recruiting?
SCHOOLGIRL
Does the floor get a medal too?
IONA VALE
Nope! It's already beaten our entire flight school!


SCHOOLGIRL
You're the one they got out, right?
PIP ARDEN
Yeah. I'm hoping to have a different hobby this month.
CAPTAIN BEAM
Young citizens! Here's how to recognise a hero from orbit!
TIK • TIK • TOOOM
ROOK SEN
Please tell me this isn't the fitting guide.


CAPTAIN BEAM / TAVI ORR
A medal makes your courage visible!
VICTORY WINDOW EXPLAINS: MEDALS
From several streets away.
CAPTAIN BEAM / TAVI ORR
Bigger medals mean bigger heroes!
Same legs, though.
CAPTAIN BEAM / TAVI ORR
Our decorations help you stand out!
Standing up costs extra.
CAPTAIN BEAM / TAVI ORR
Even in silence, your medal speaks for you!
Mostly it says, 'Help.'
CAPTAIN BEAM / TAVI ORR
Stay bright. Stay Martian. Stand by your achievement!
Beside it. Much safer.


SCHOOLGIRL
Can you take it off?
ROOK SEN
Yes. They prefer we discover that after the photograph.
IONA VALE
There! Bigger hero, smaller Rook! Everybody wins!
SERA VENN
Twelve children, teacher. All with you.
PIP ARDEN
I think your medal's got its own fan club.

PIP · LATER

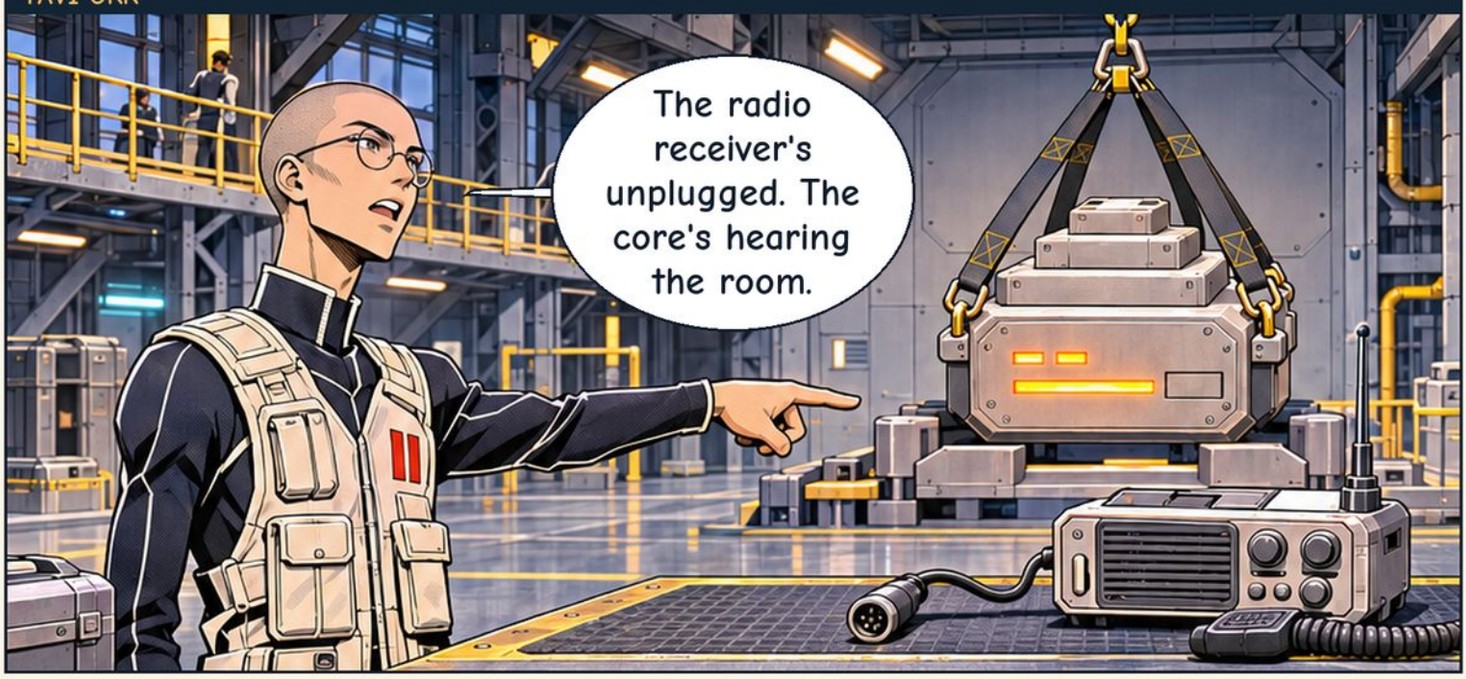
Dock 9 was our training dock in orbit. Needlewake was our ship; Moth, her little rescue launch.

CAPTAIN BEAM

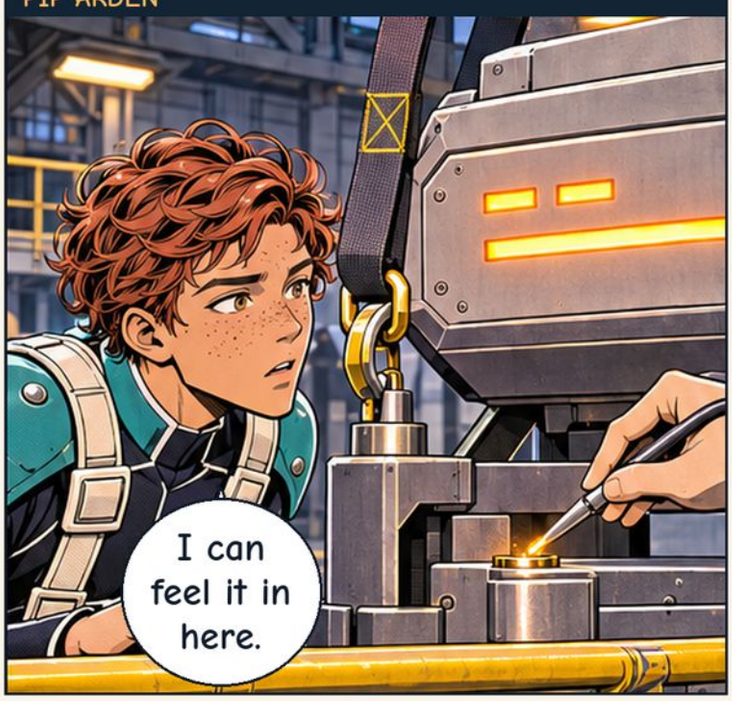
PIP · LATER

The core was a thirty-centimetre block that set machinery's pace. Our engineer Tavi brought it back. It copied the jingle's beat. Terrible taste in music.

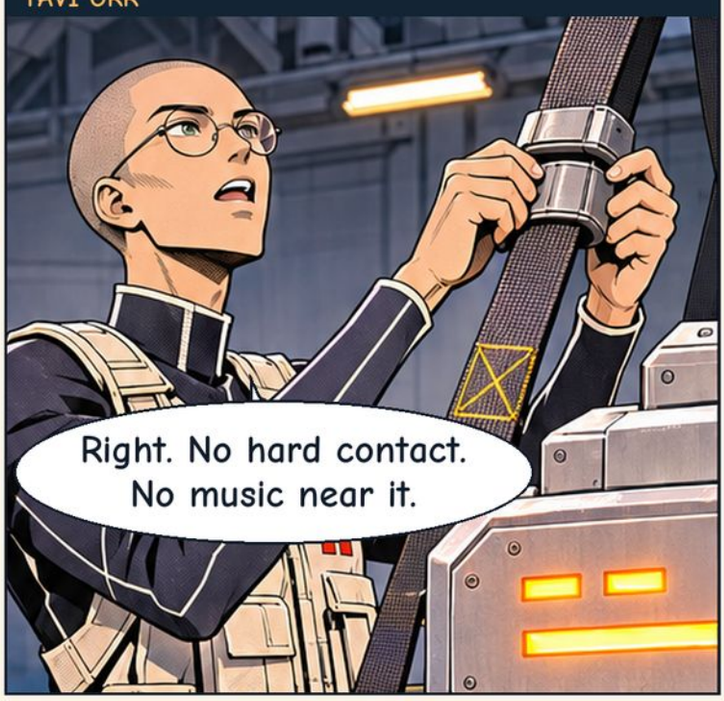
TAVI ORR



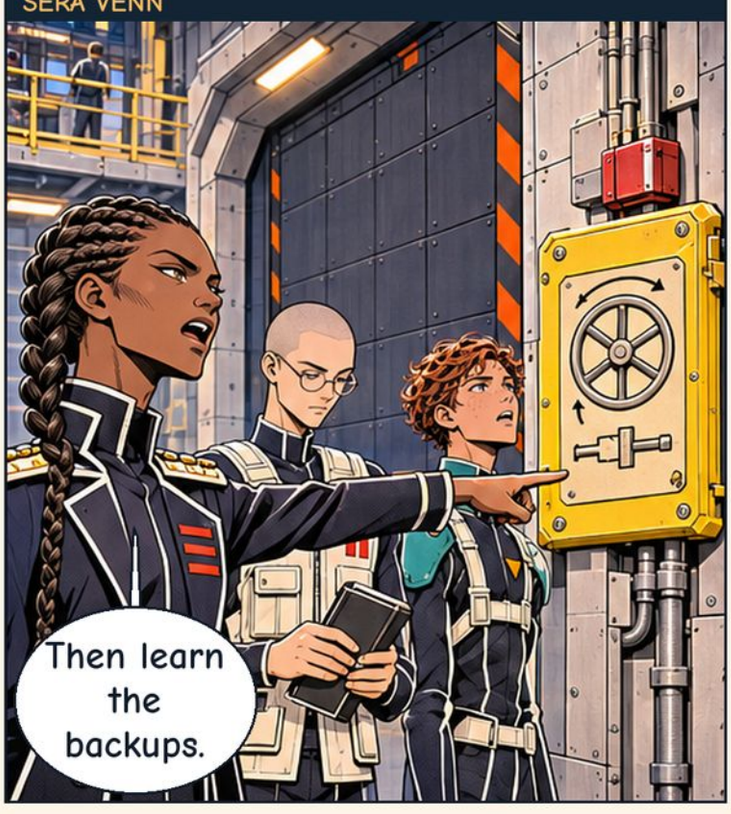
PIP ARDEN



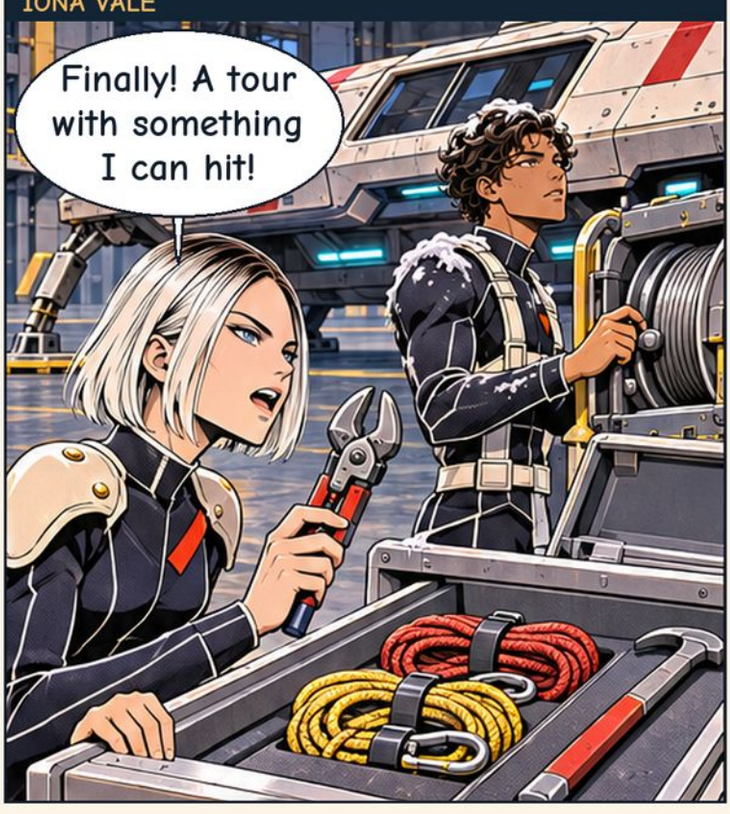
TAVI ORR

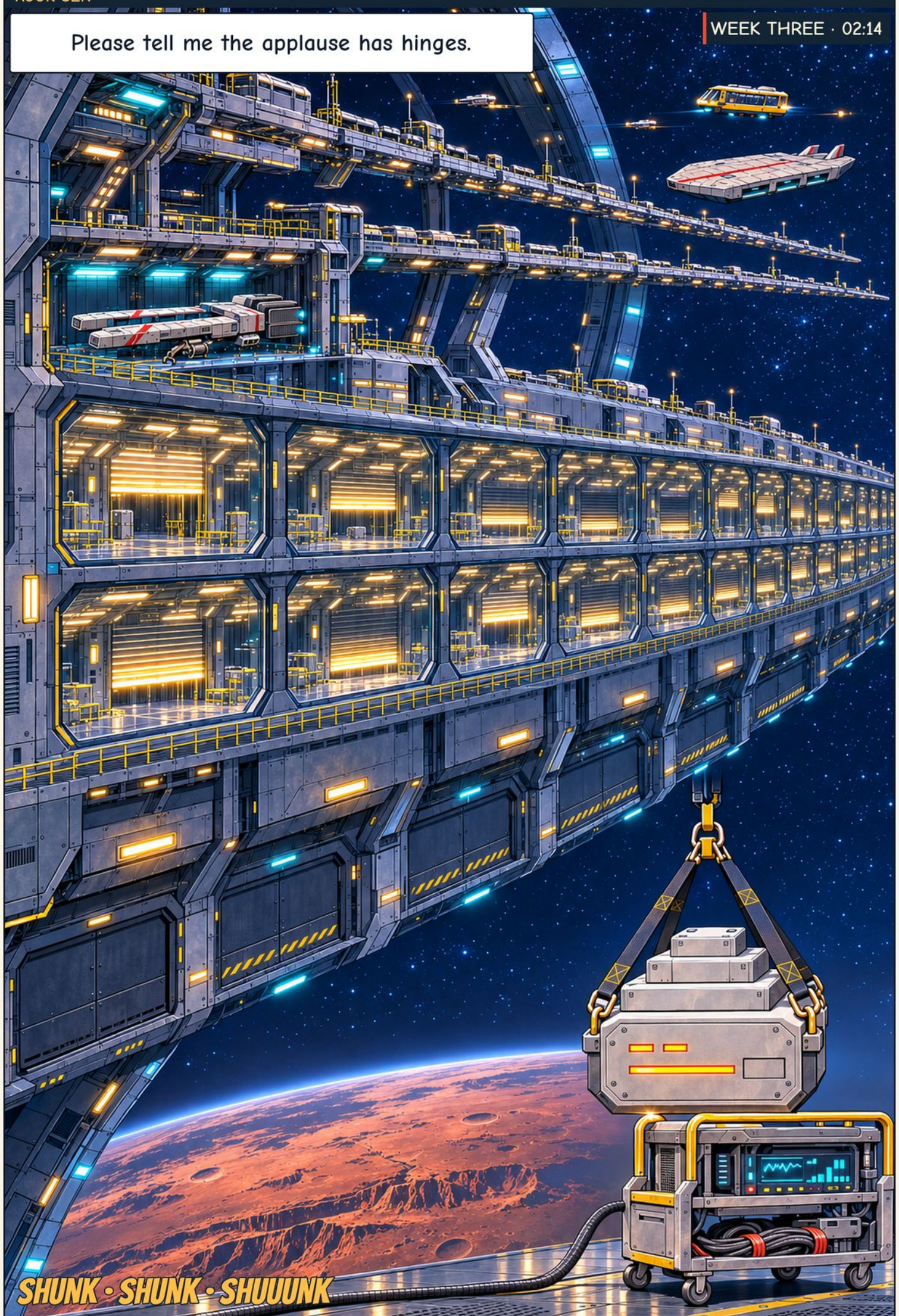


SERA VENN



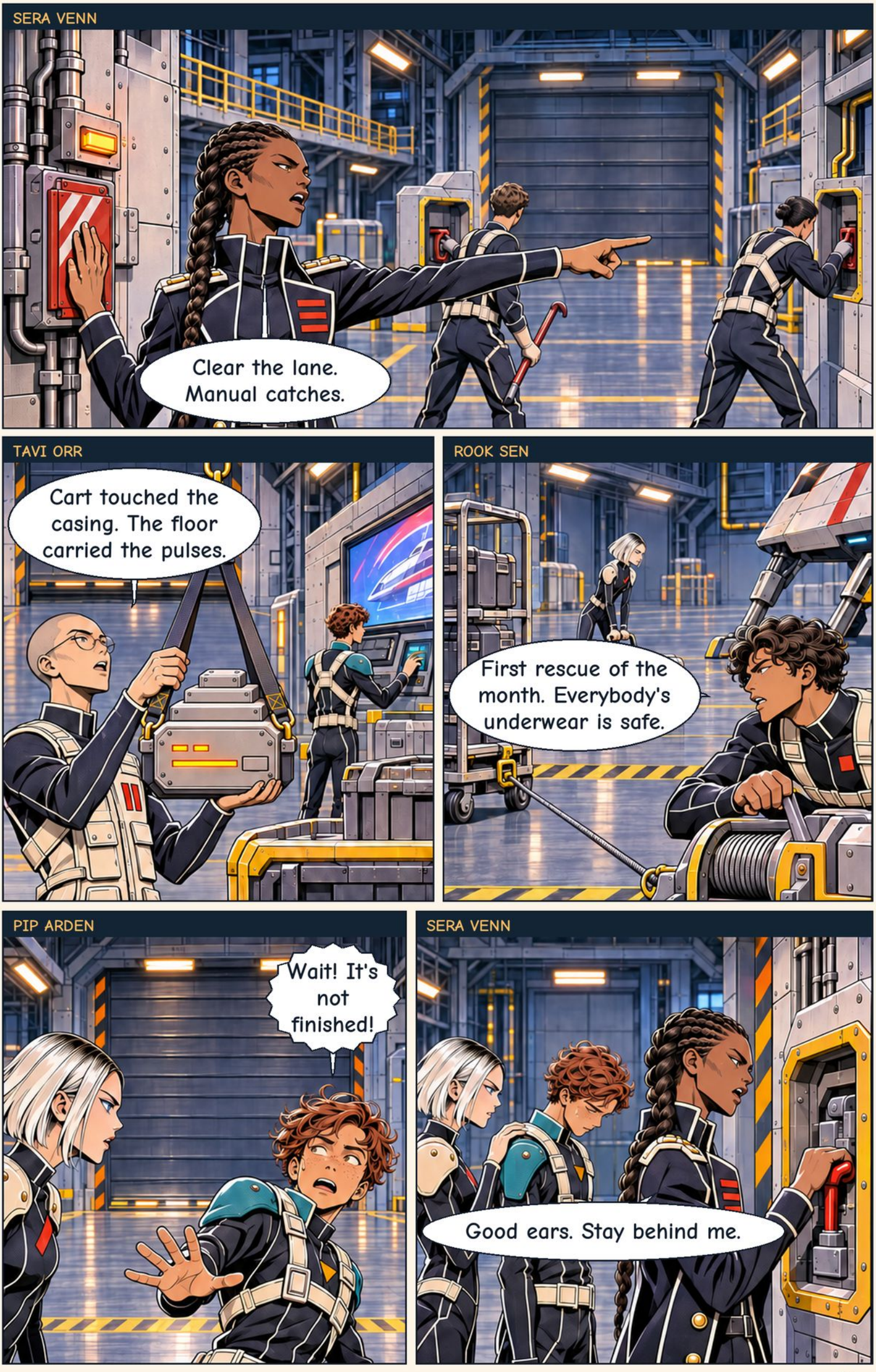
IONA VALE





PIP · LATER

A stage cable dragged the cart against the core. Beam's all-night publicity loop shook the casing; the gates moved. Rook towed a luggage rack clear.


SERA VENN
Clear the lane. Manual catches.
TAVI ORR
Cart touched the casing. The floor carried the pulses.
ROOK SEN
First rescue of the month. Everybody's underwear is safe.
PIP ARDEN
Wait! It's not finished!
SERA VENN
Good ears. Stay behind me.

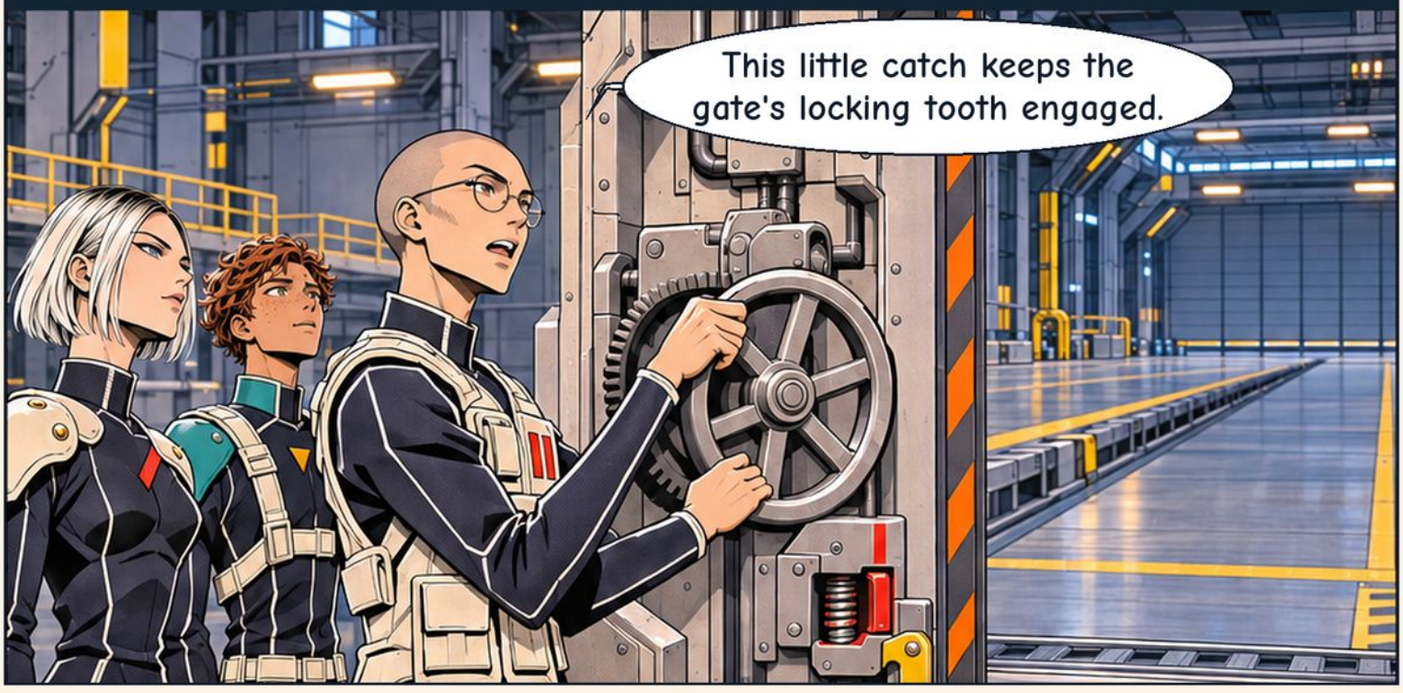
PIP · LATER

The locking tooth held the gate's weight. The little catch kept that tooth in. We practised holding the catch.

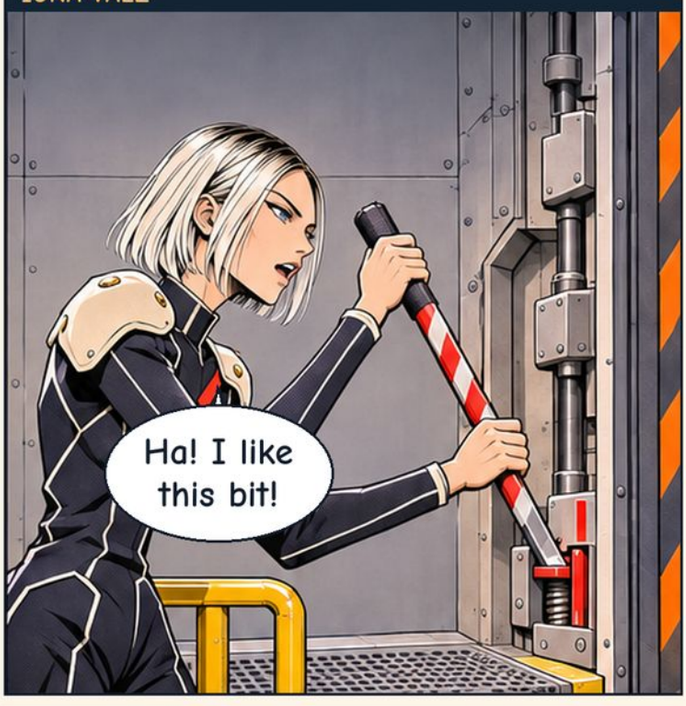
TAVI ORR

GATE A / MANUAL BACKUP

BAR	→	CATCH	→	LOCKING TOOTH
holds the catch in		keeps the tooth engaged		lets the gate rise stops it dropping



IONA VALE



PIP ARDEN

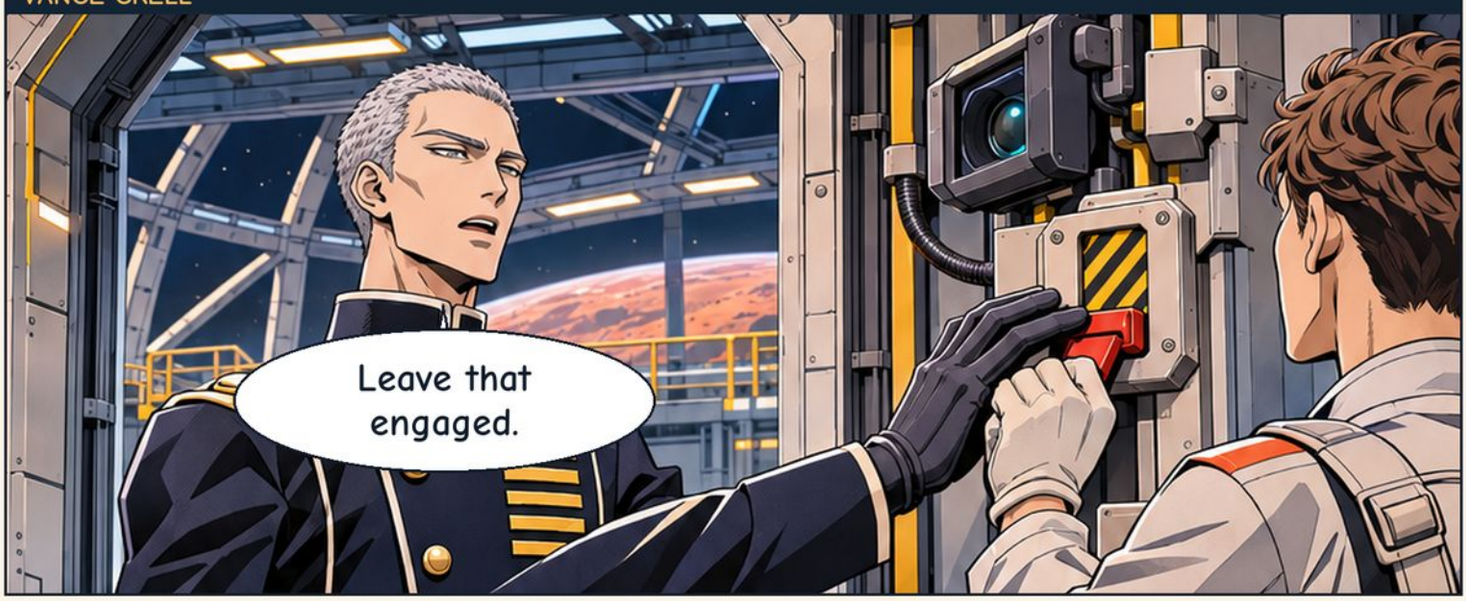
SERA VENN

PIP ARDEN

PIP · LATER

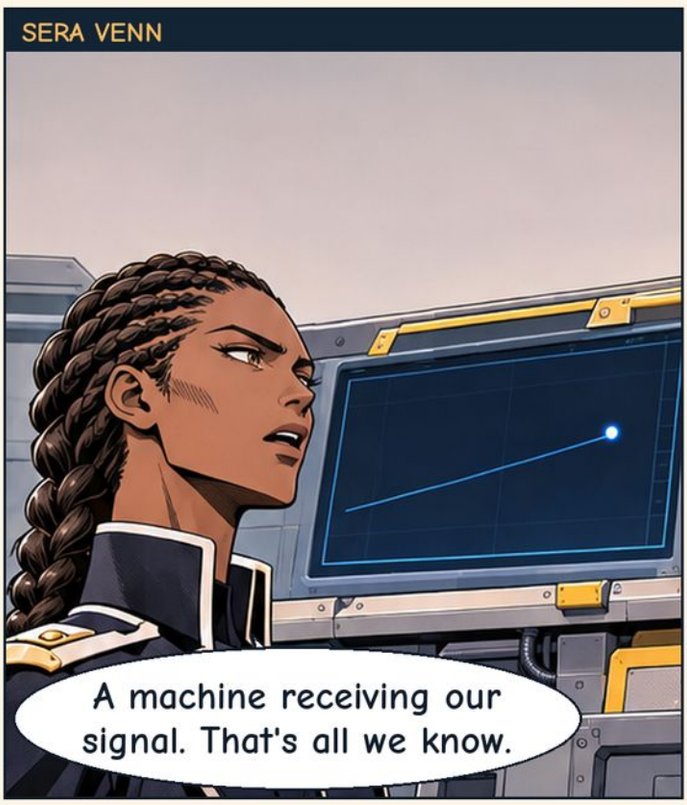
The core came from an ancient machine in orbit. Its signal led towards another receiver near Earth. Commodore Crell came to collect it.

VANCE CRELL



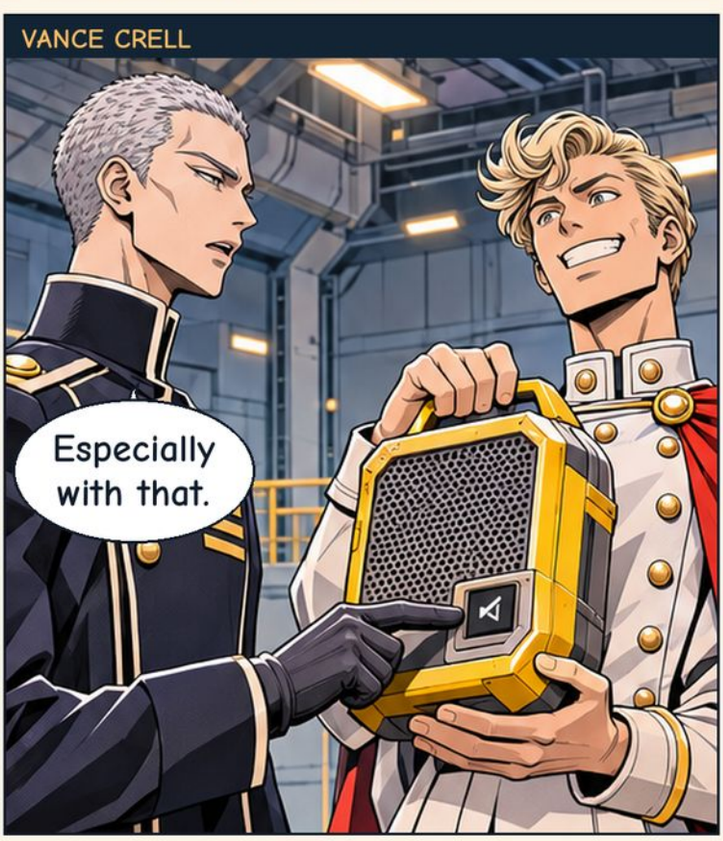
VANCE CRELL

SERA VENN



VANCE CRELL

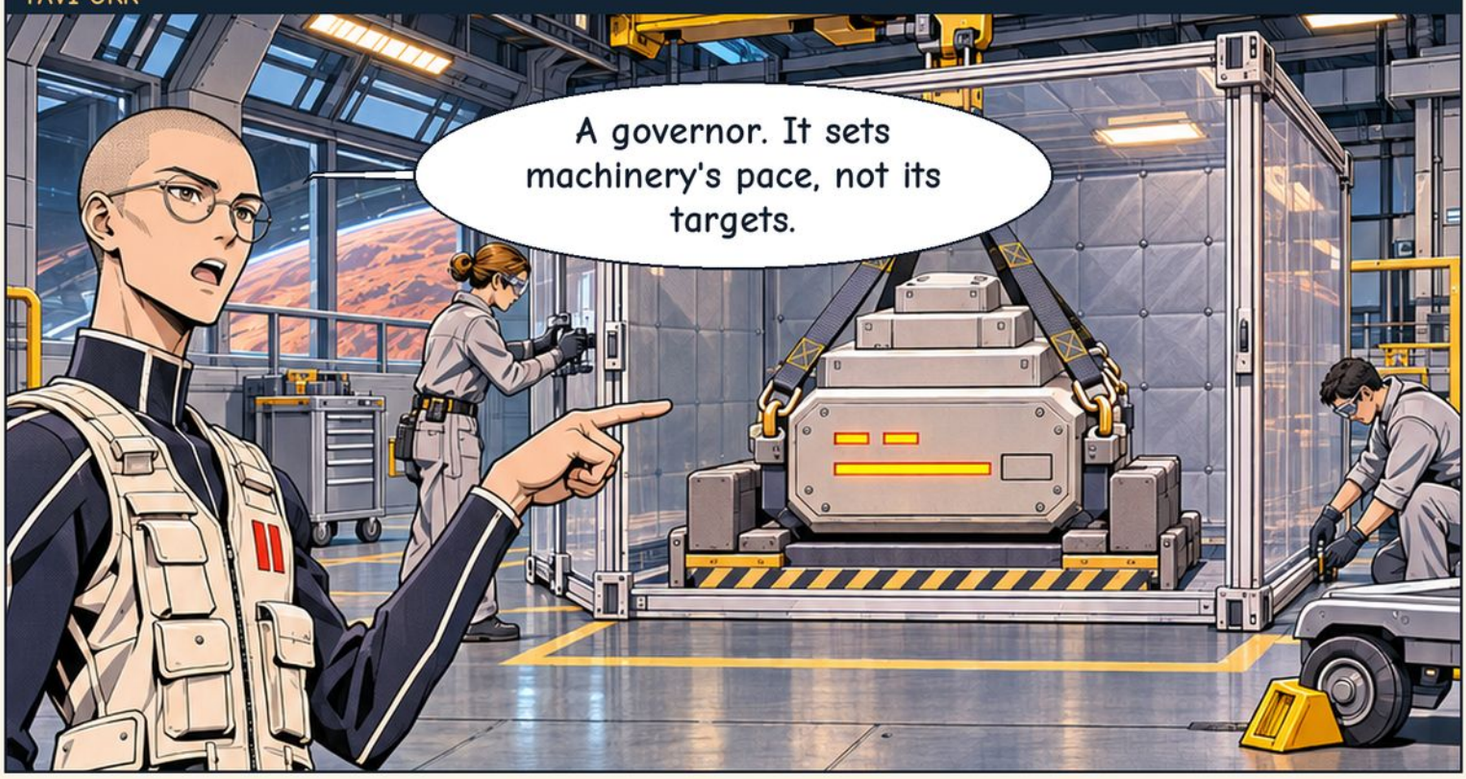
VANCE CRELL



PIP · LATER

Behind workshop glass, the core hung from the beam above the pod rails. Cloth should stop the vibrations, we thought. The proper case hadn't arrived.

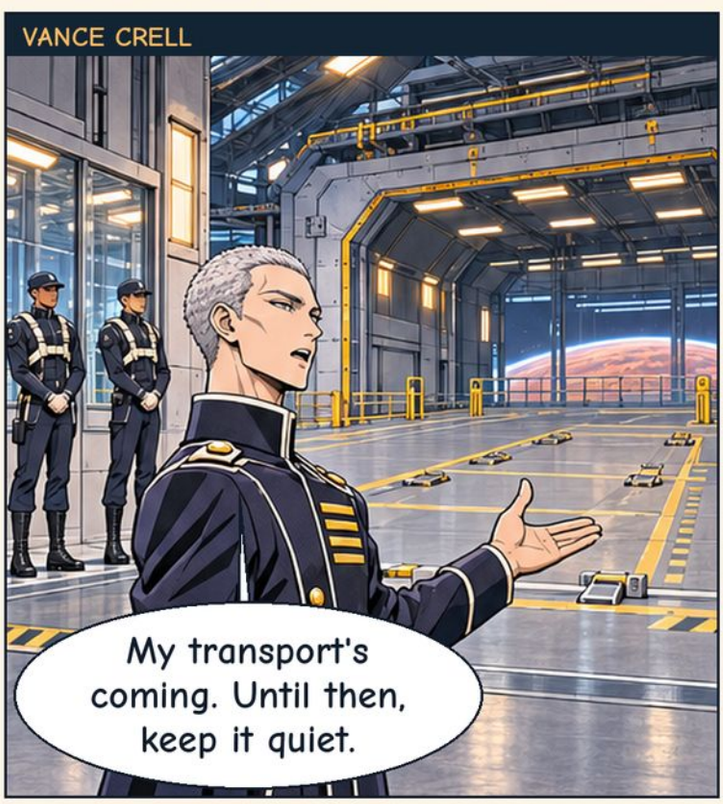
TAVI ORR



VANCE CRELL

SERA VENN

VANCE CRELL



CAPTAIN BEAM

PIP · LATER

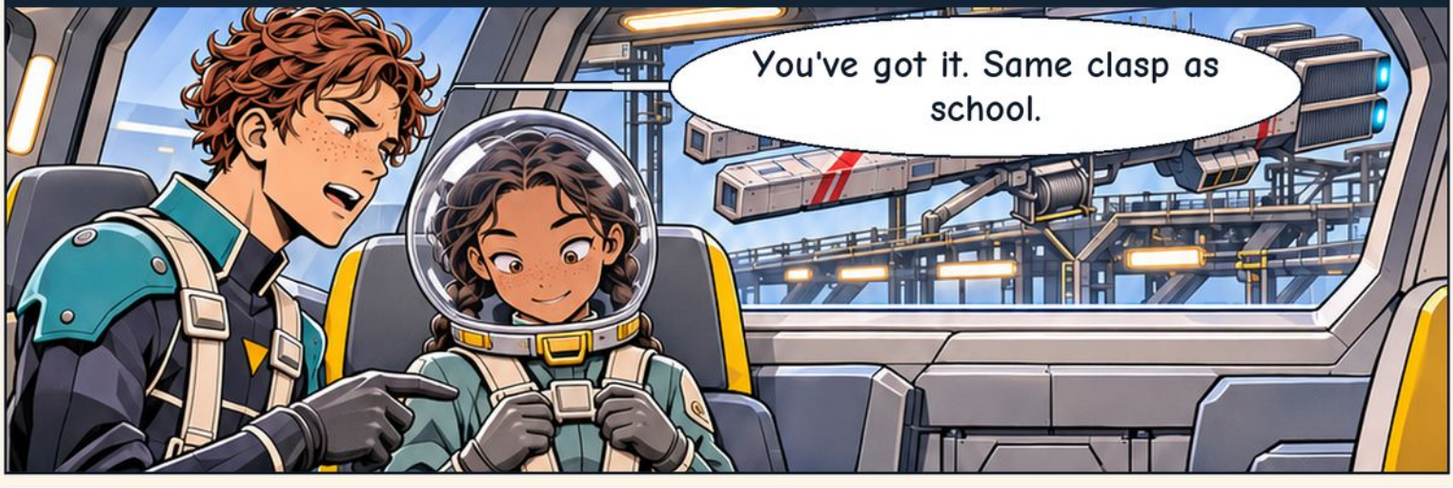
Twelve children and their teacher boarded the tour bus after the ferry docked. Its driver made fourteen. We stepped out. Internal gates. No vacuum.

SCHOOLGIRL

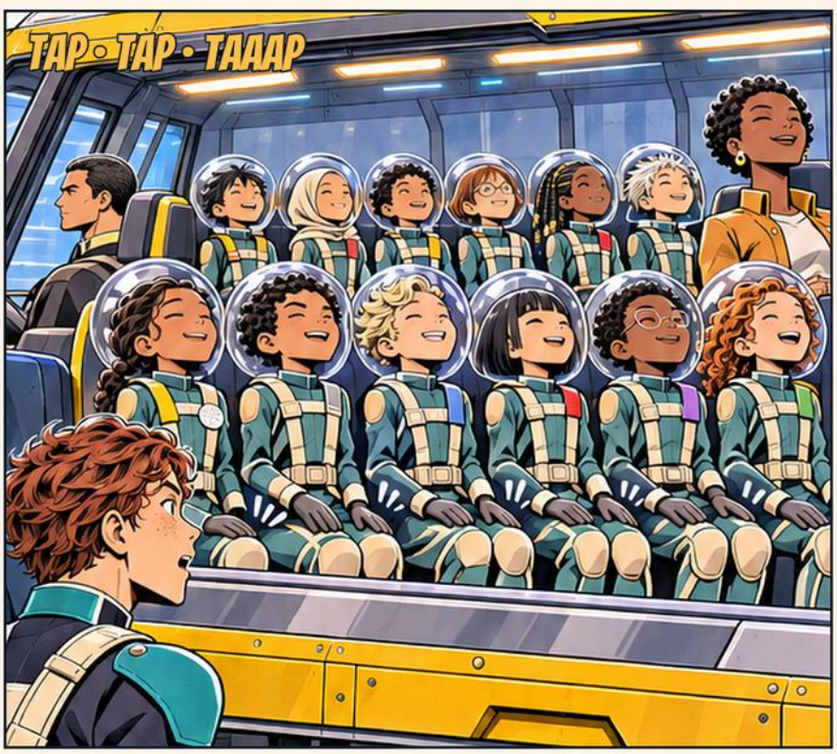
ROOK SEN

SERA VENN

PIP ARDEN

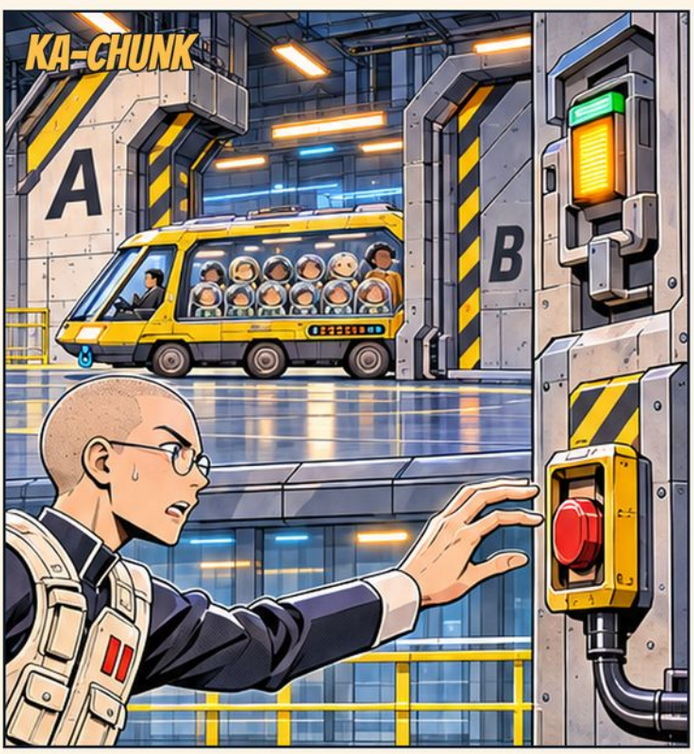


SCHOOLGIRL



PIP · LATER

The children tapped the jingle on their knees. Rails, shared beam, tight sling: it reached the core. The core shook the gates.

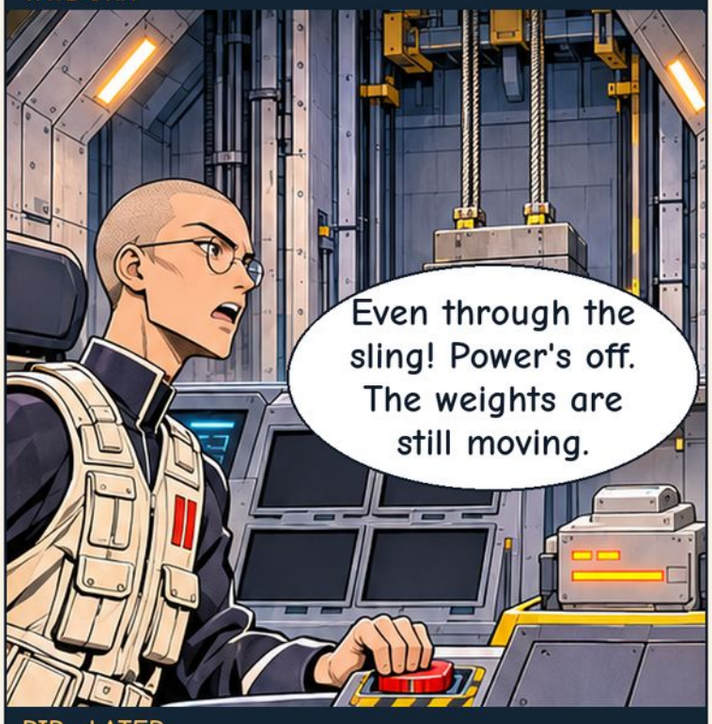


PIP · LATER

Gate B crushed the rear bracket; A dropped ahead. We had to tow the whole cabin through. No child was crossing under that blade unprotected.

PIP ARDEN

TAVI ORR



PIP · LATER

The weights were heavy moving blocks that helped operate the gates. Cutting electricity didn't stop them mid-stroke.

SERA VENN

CAPTAIN BEAM

SERA VENN

RESCUE ROUTE / WEST IS LEFT

SAFE BERTH / MOTH
ROOK: TOW REEL

A

SCHOOL POD
IONA: FREE REAR WHEEL

B

EAST

A: PIP + SERA / MAIN CATCH; TAVI / HANDWHEEL; CRELL / BACKUP

West through A. Rook, tow.

PIP · LATER

Moth stayed parked. Its powered tow reel pulled a steel cable. Rook worked the reel; Iona hooked the cable to the pod.

ROOK SEN

Reel's ready. I'd prefer something less full of children.

PIP ARDEN

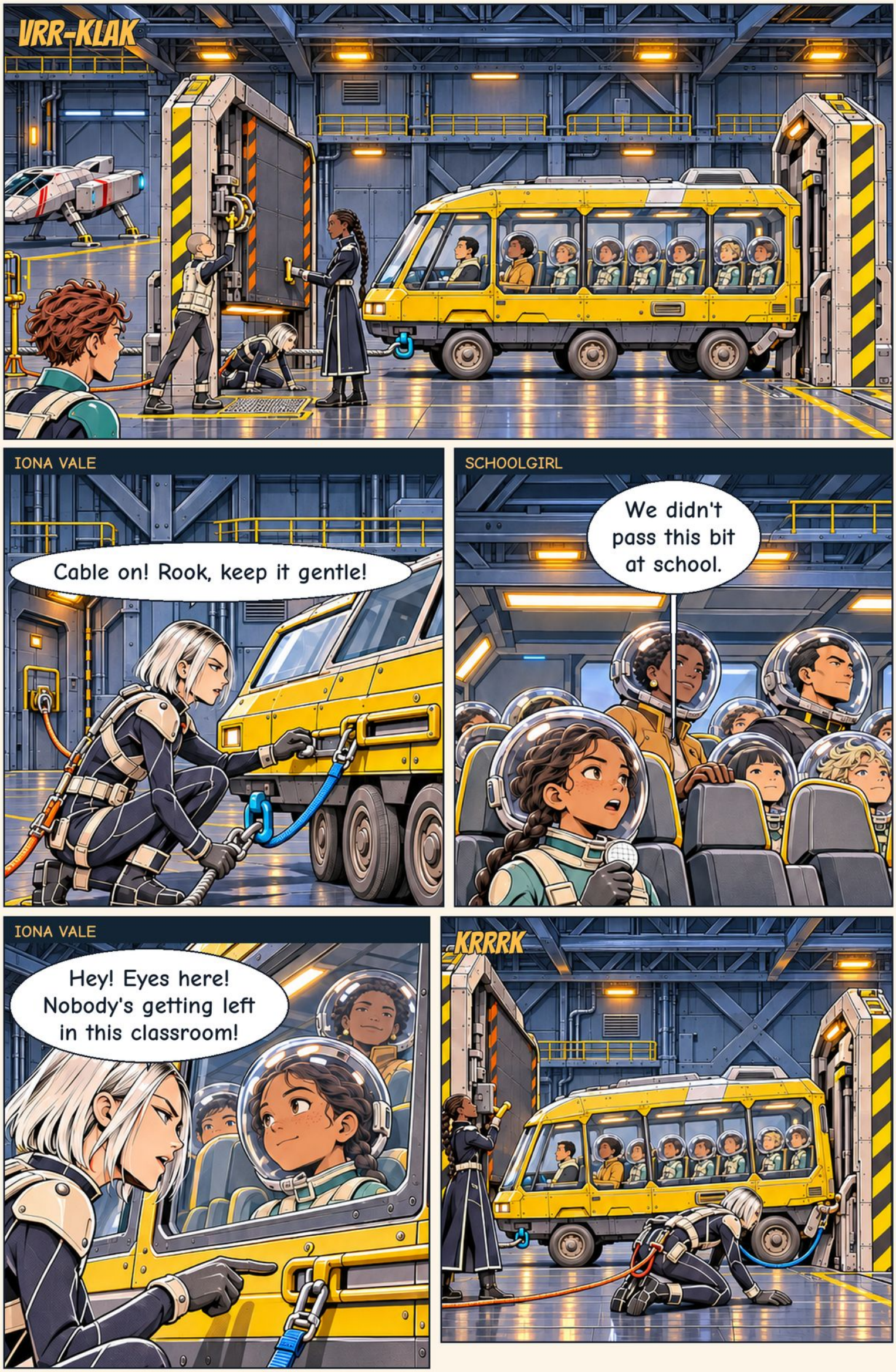
That little click. That's when it drops.

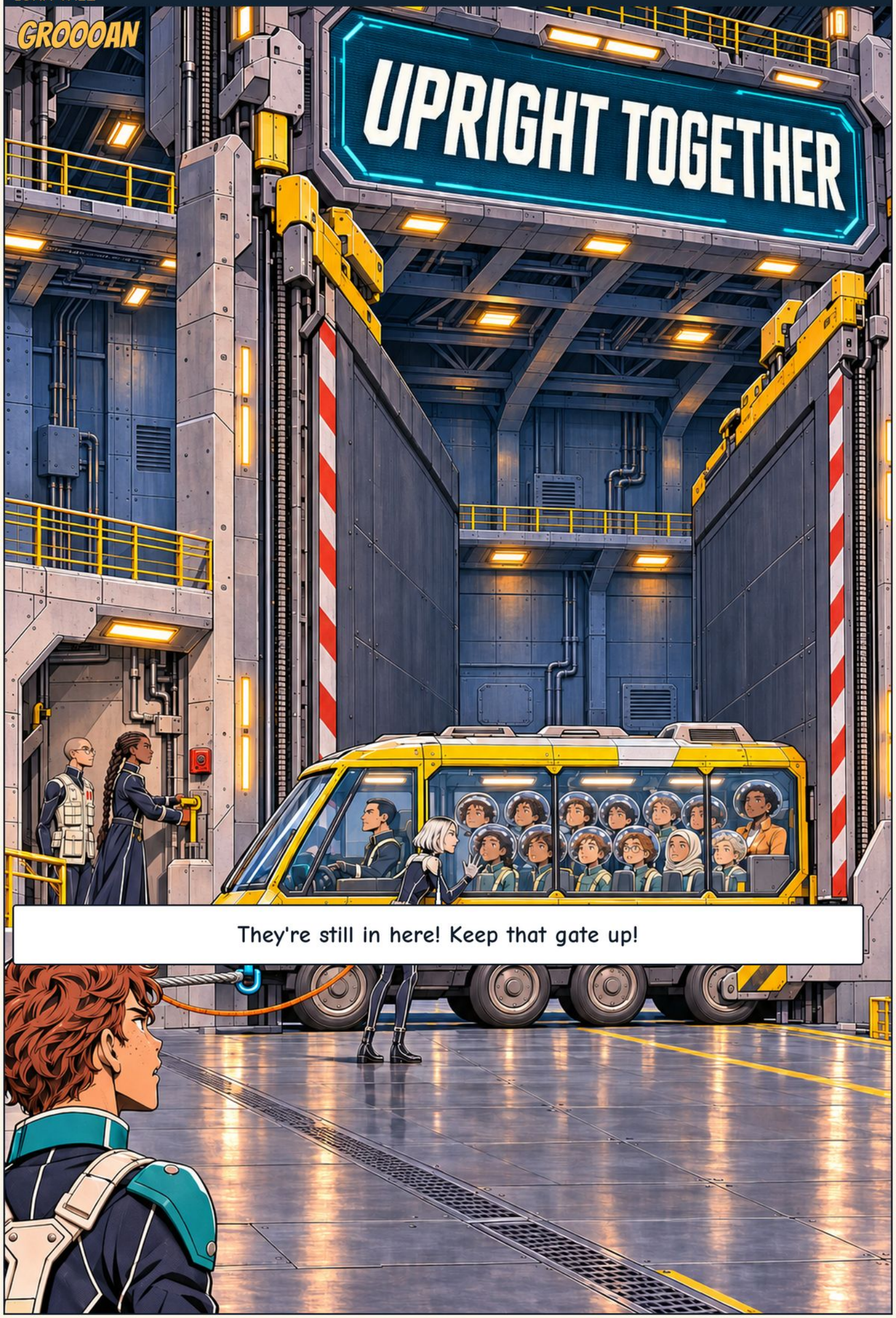
TAVI ORR

Keep that catch in. I can raise it.

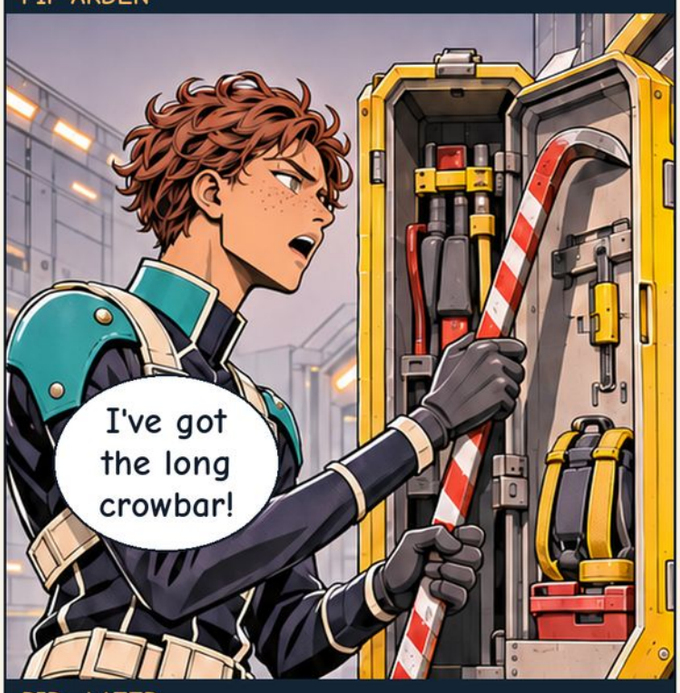
IONA VALE

Open it, Tavi! I'm bringing the whole class back!


VRR-KLAK
IONA VALE
Cable on! Rook, keep it gentle!
SCHOOLGIRL
We didn't pass this bit at school.
IONA VALE
Hey! Eyes here! Nobody's getting left in this classroom!
KRRRK


GROOOAN
UPRIGHT TOGETHER
They're still in here! Keep that gate up!

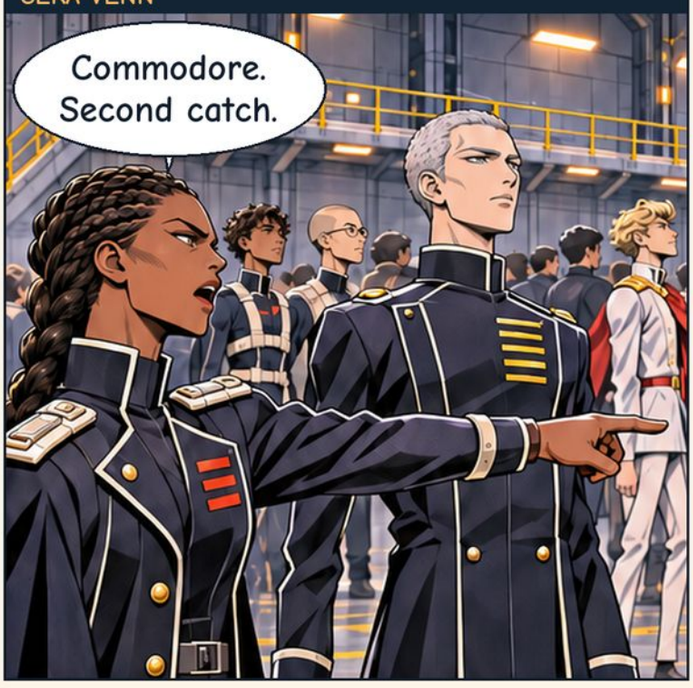
PIP ARDEN



PIP · LATER

Sera's short catch handle snapped. I grabbed her long crowbar, the one we'd practised with.

SERA VENN

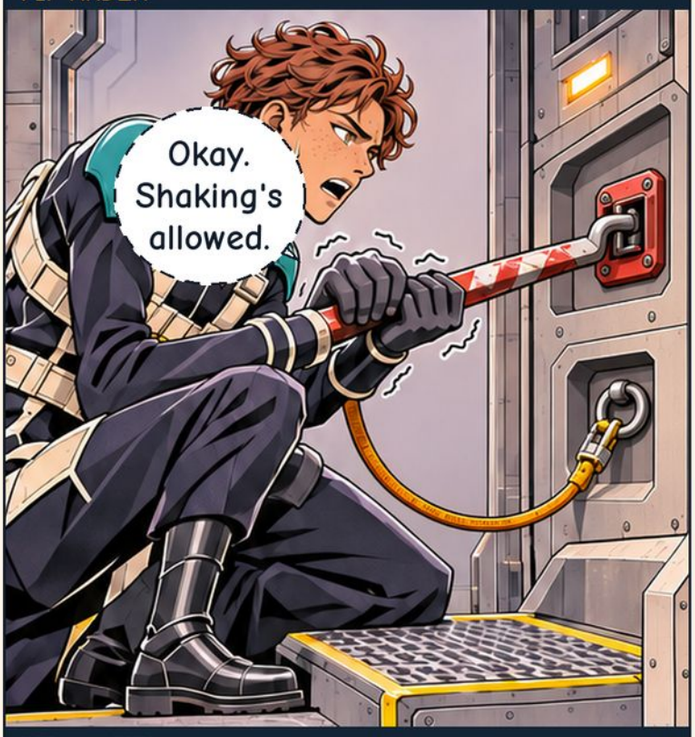


VANCE CRELL

PIP · LATER

Crell's backup held Gate A one notch too low for the pod. Tavi could crank it higher only while I held the main catch.

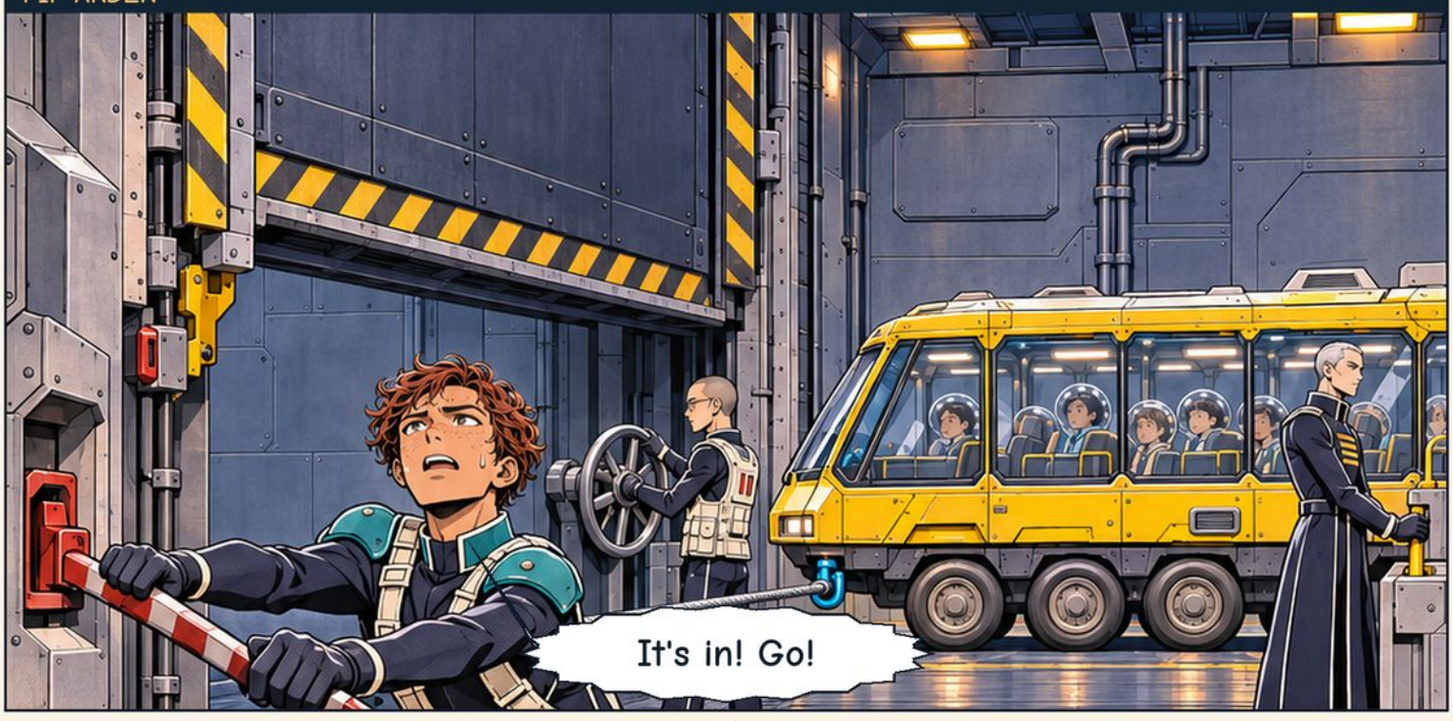
PIP ARDEN



PIP · LATER

My crowbar held the small catch. The gate's own locking tooth carried the weight. My hands hadn't read that reassurance.

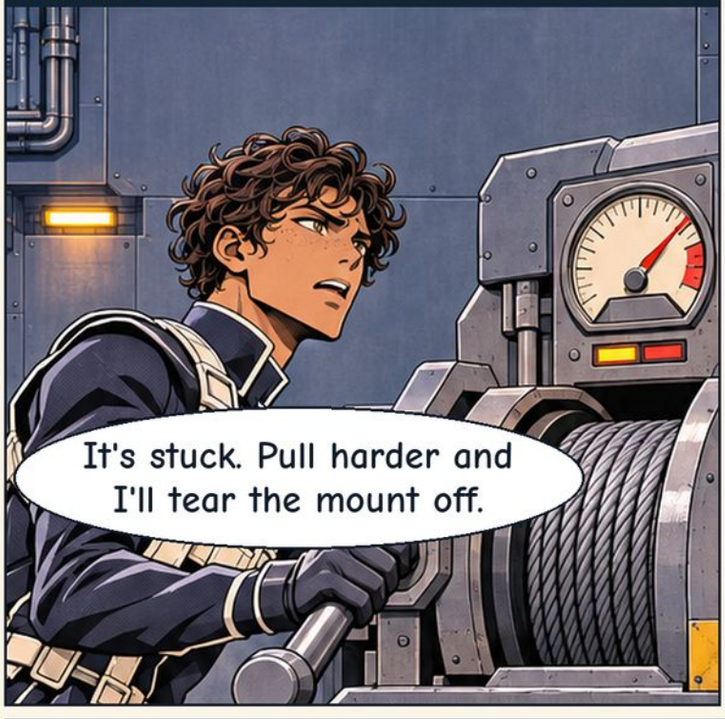
PIP ARDEN



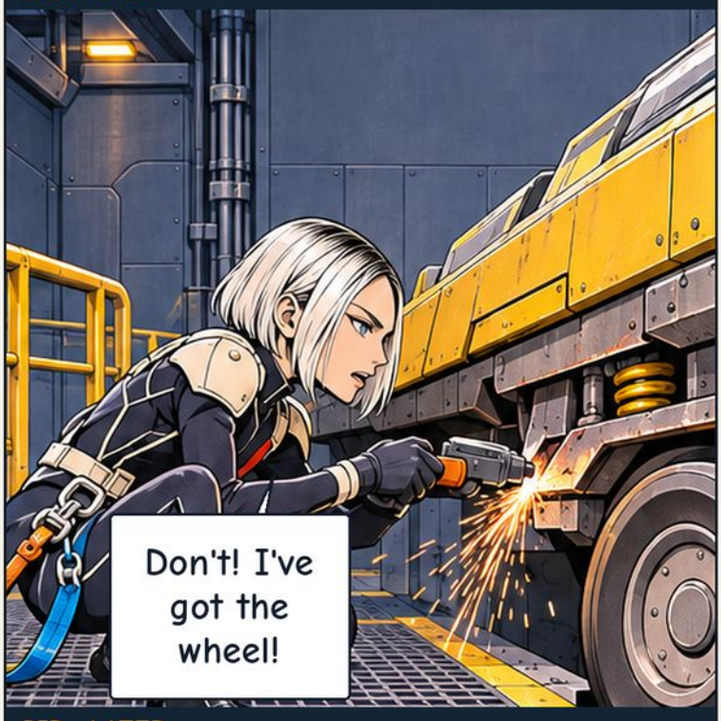
PIP · LATER

Iona had to cut the bent wheel bracket before Rook could pull. Pulling harder would rip the pod apart.

ROOK SEN



IONA VALE

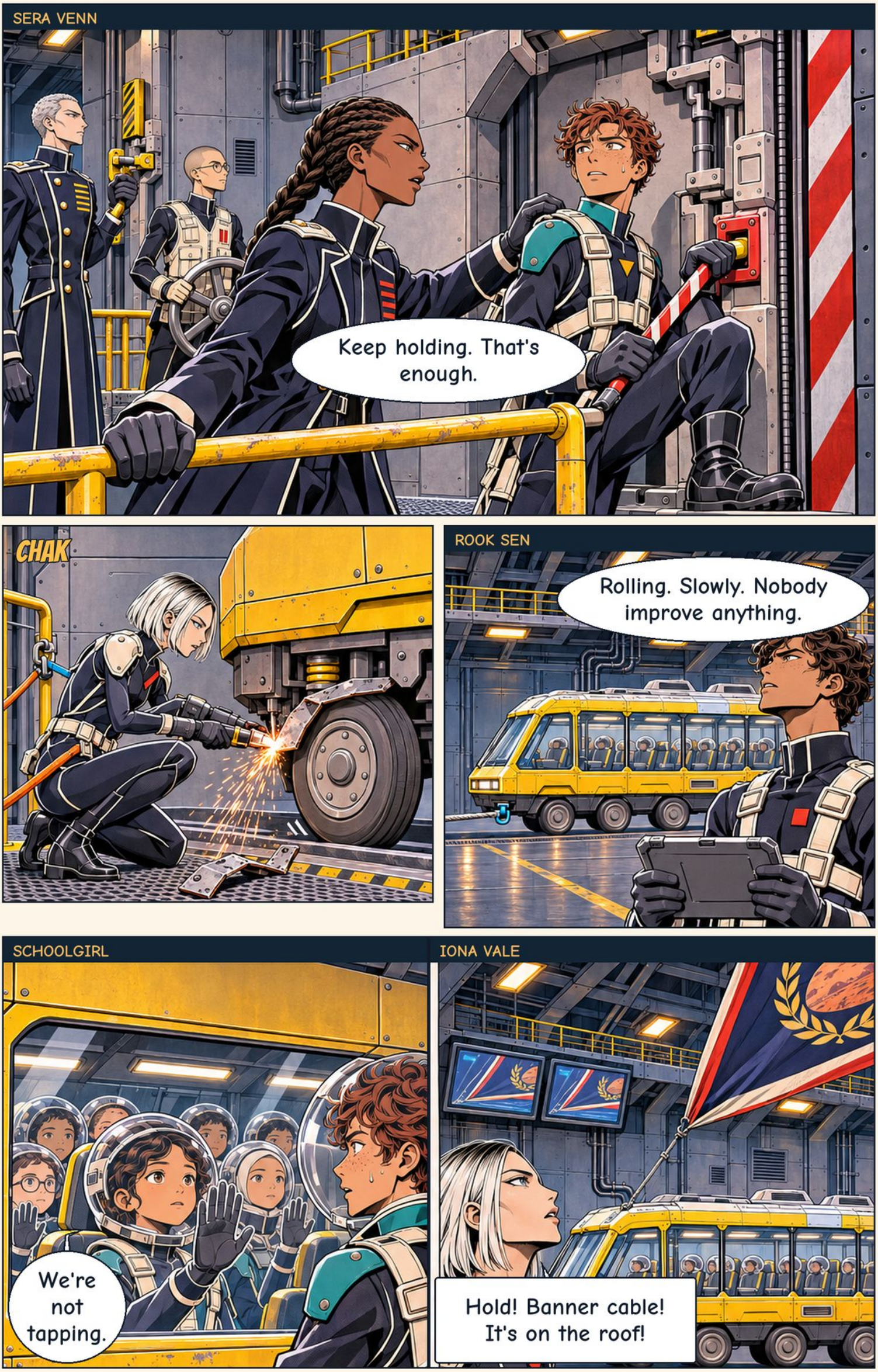


PIP · LATER

She cut the bent outer bracket, not the shaft through the wheel. The wheel stayed on, damaged but rolling.

SERA VENN

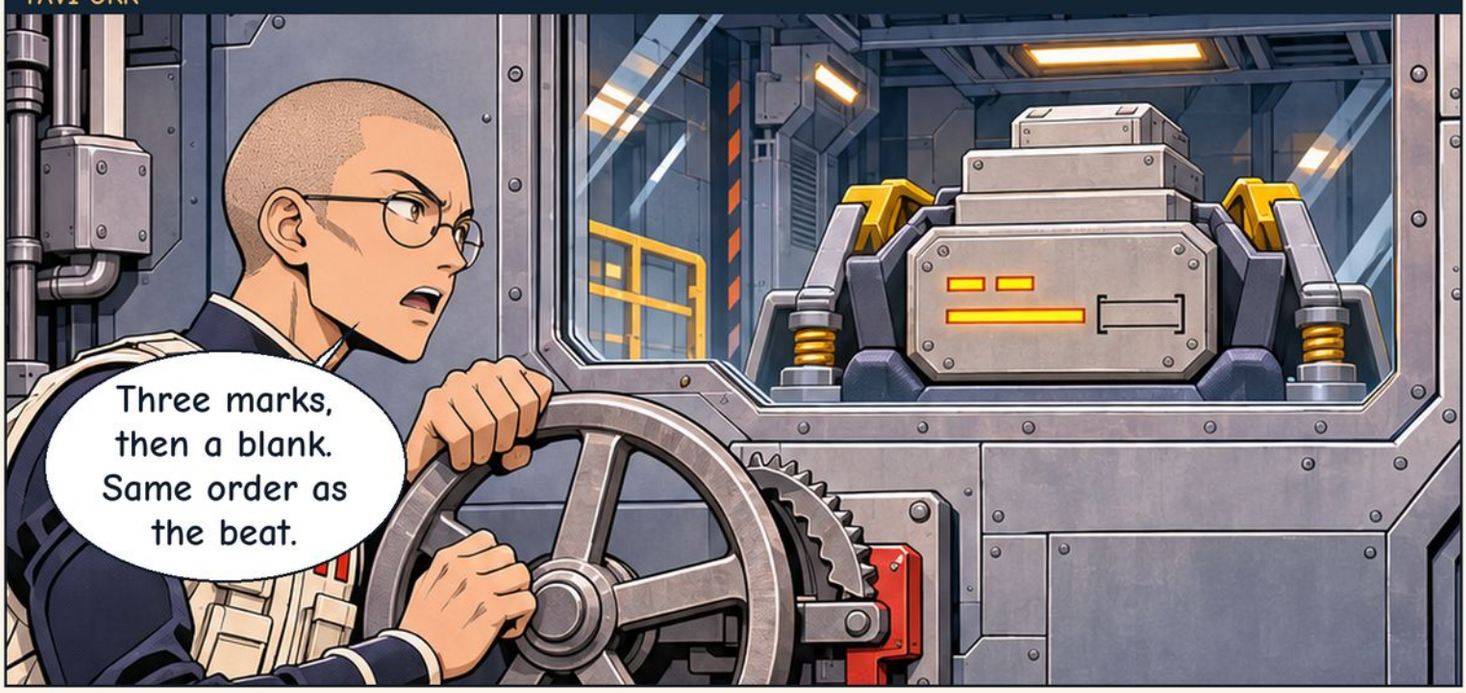
PIP ARDEN


SERA VENN
Keep holding. That's enough.
CHAK
ROOK SEN
Rolling. Slowly. Nobody improve anything.
SCHOOLGIRL
We're not tapping.
IONA VALE
Hold! Banner cable! It's on the roof!

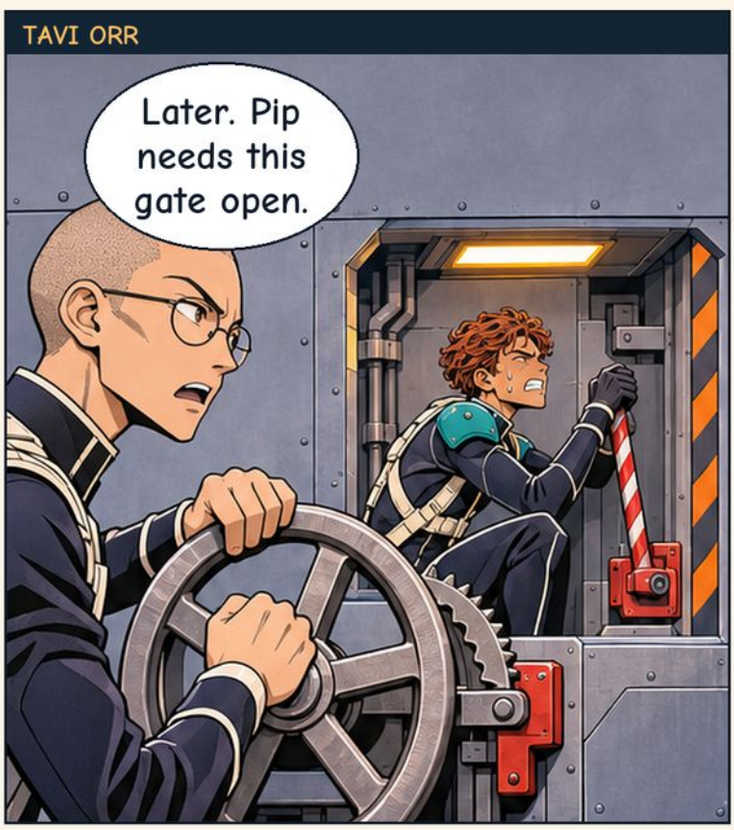
PIP · LATER

Still at the wheel, Tavi noticed a framed blank beside the three marks on the core. That empty space was part of the pattern.

TAVI ORR

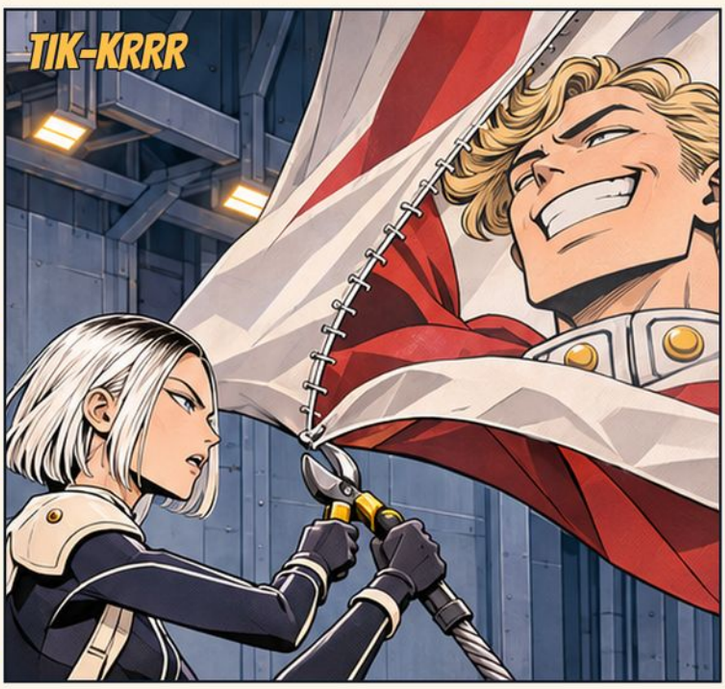


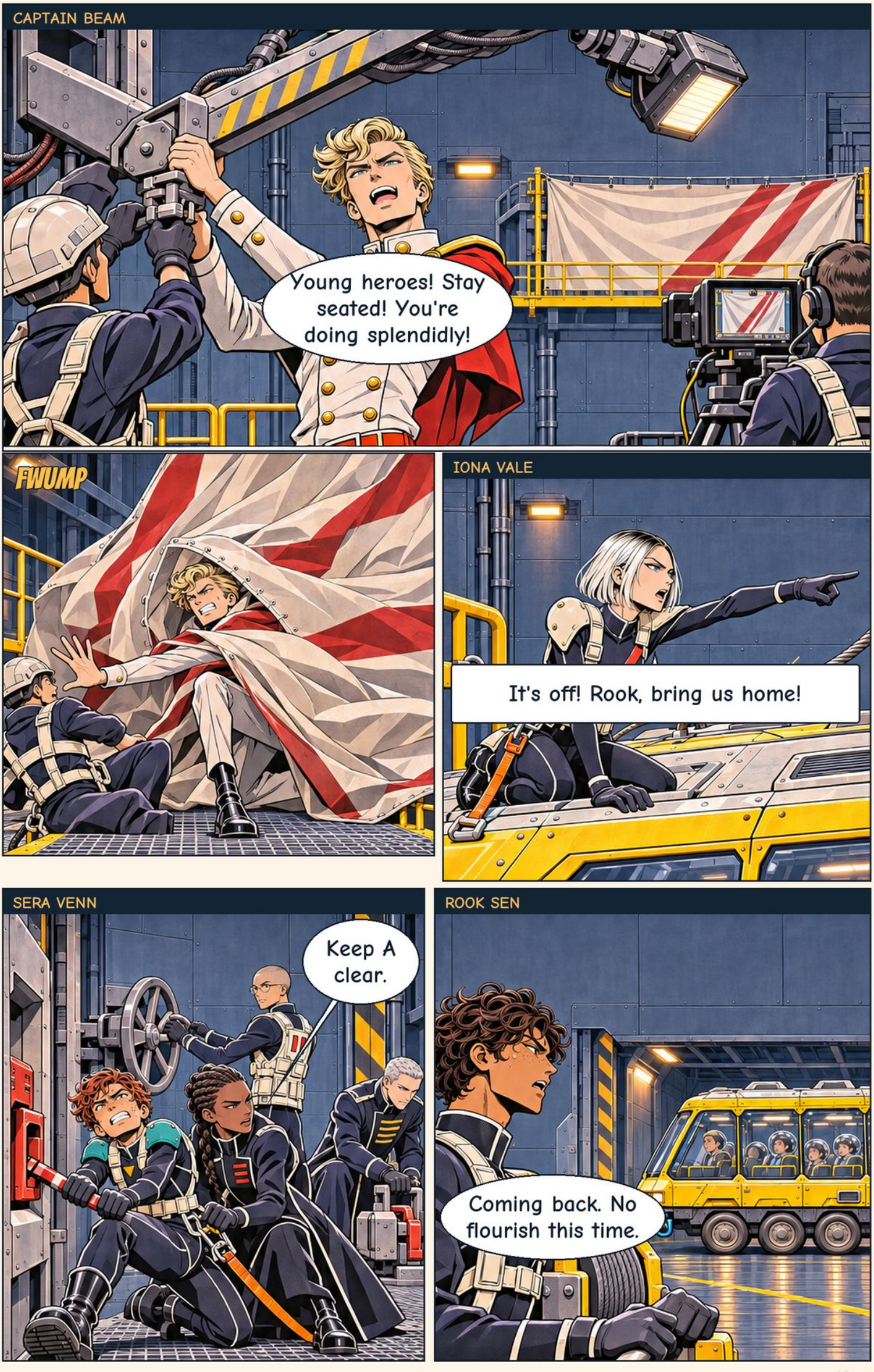
TAVI ORR

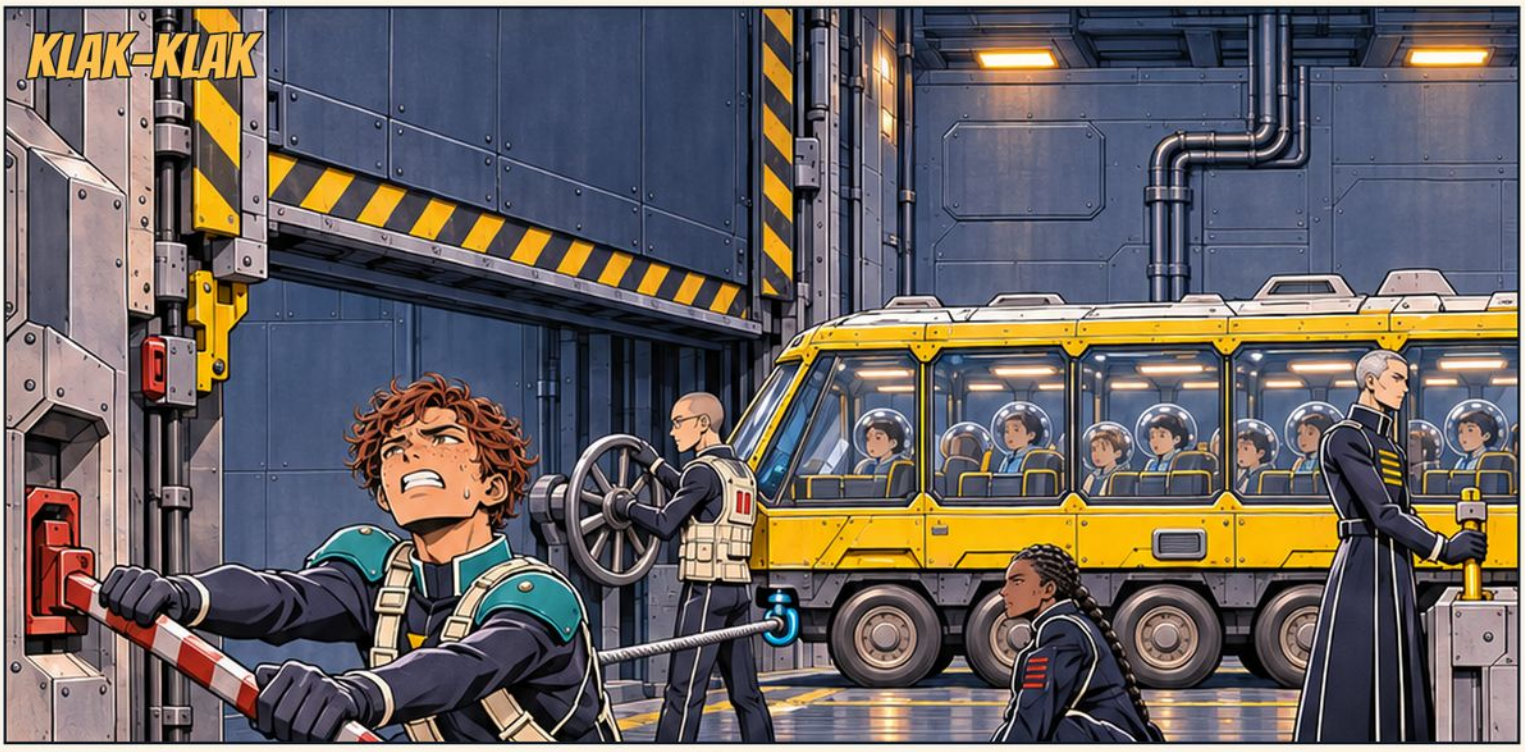


IONA VALE

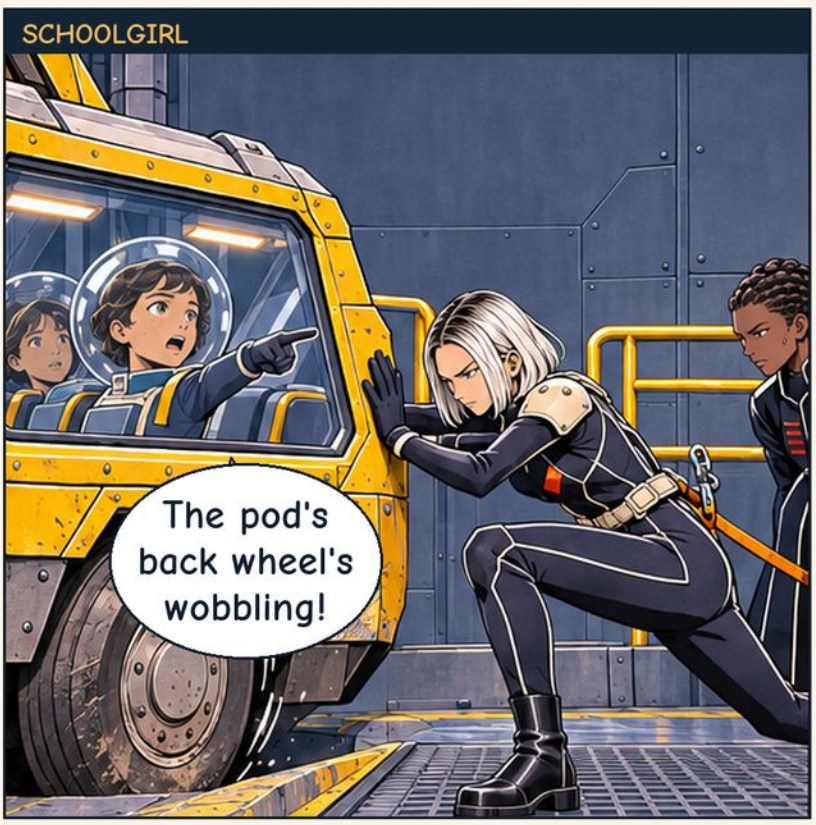
ROOK SEN

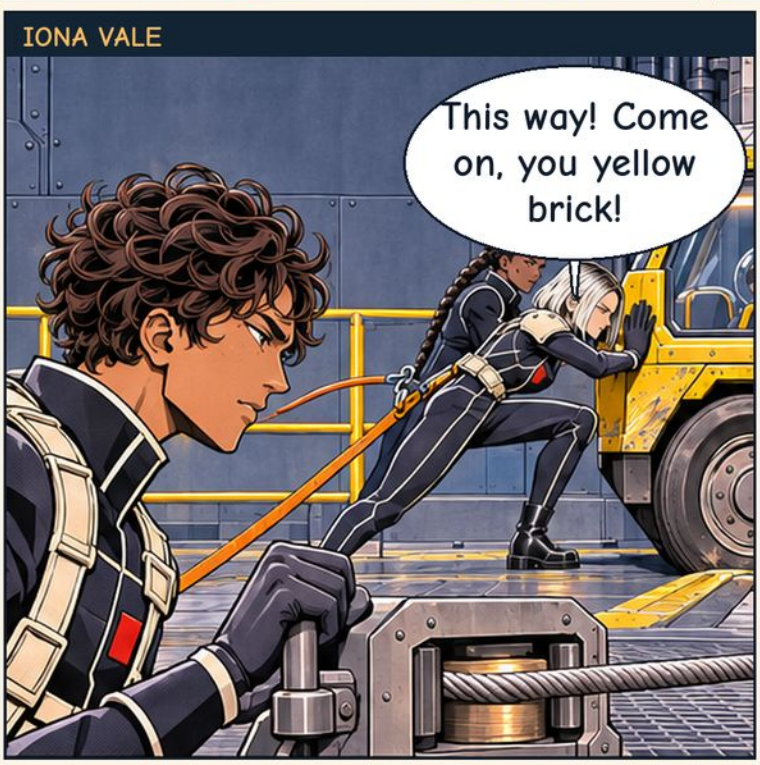


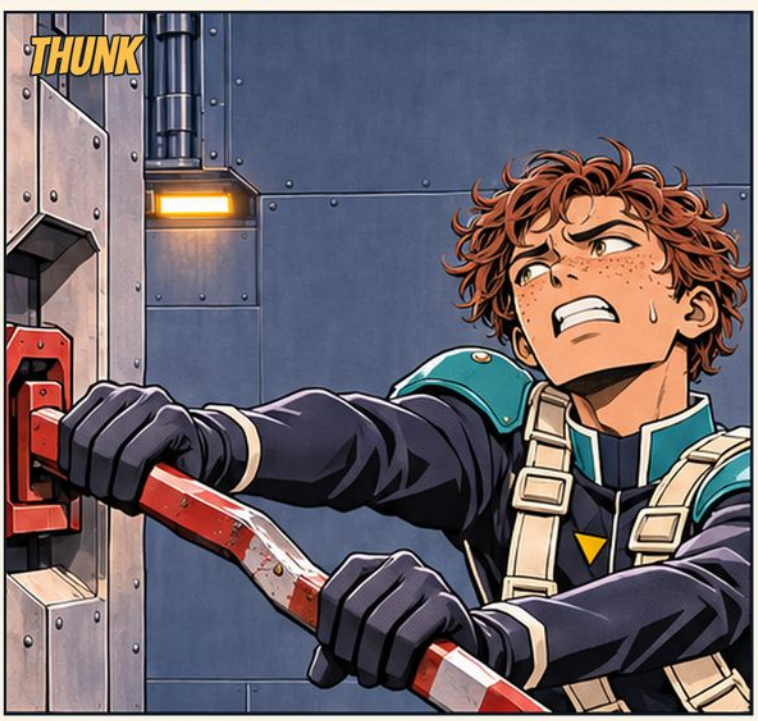

CAPTAIN BEAM
Young heroes! Stay seated! You're doing splendidly!
FWUMP
IONA VALE
It's off! Rook, bring us home!
SERA VENN
Keep A clear.
ROOK SEN
Coming back. No flourish this time.


KLAK-KLAK

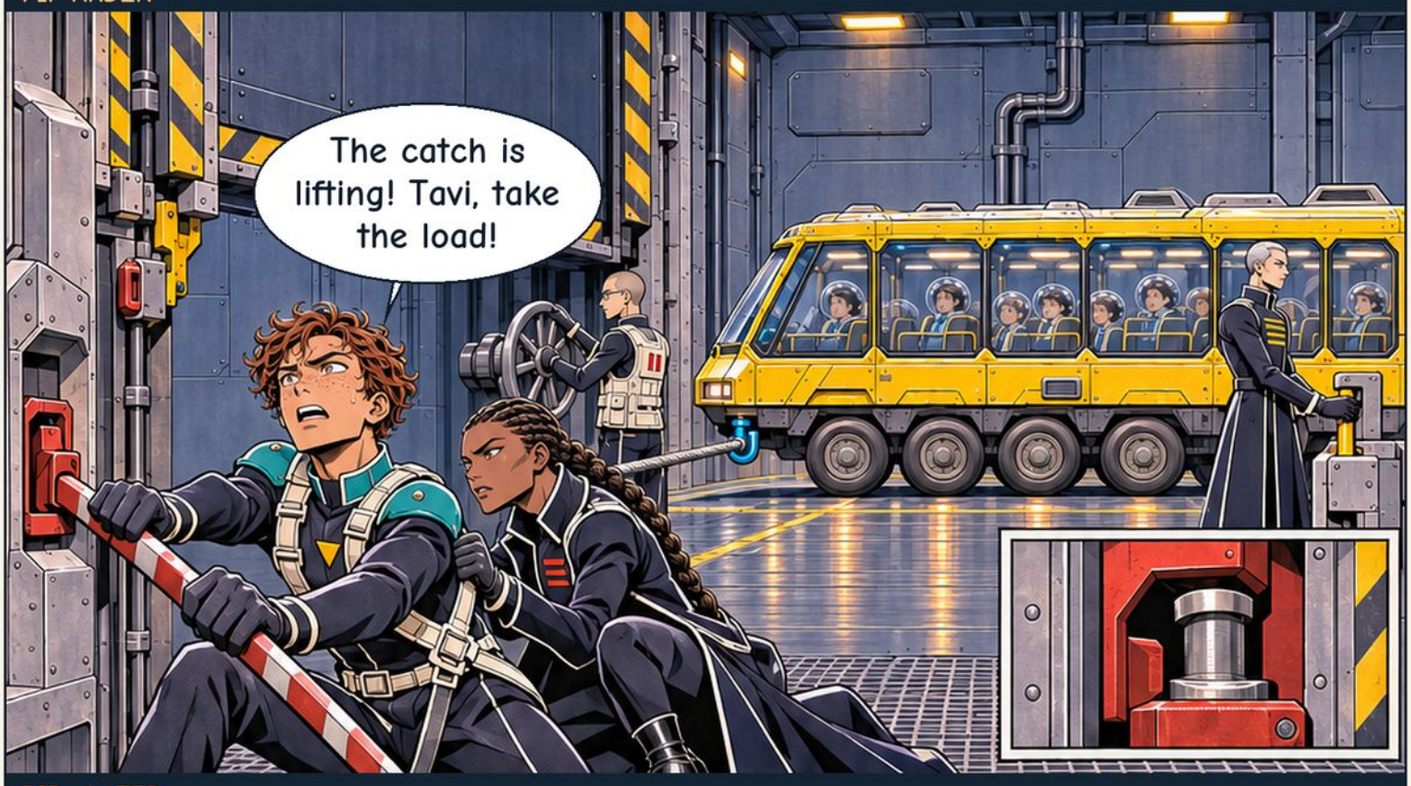
PIP ARDEN
You've got to keep going. Please.


SCHOOLGIRL
The pod's back wheel's wobbling!


IONA VALE
This way! Come on, you yellow brick!


THUNK

PIP ARDEN



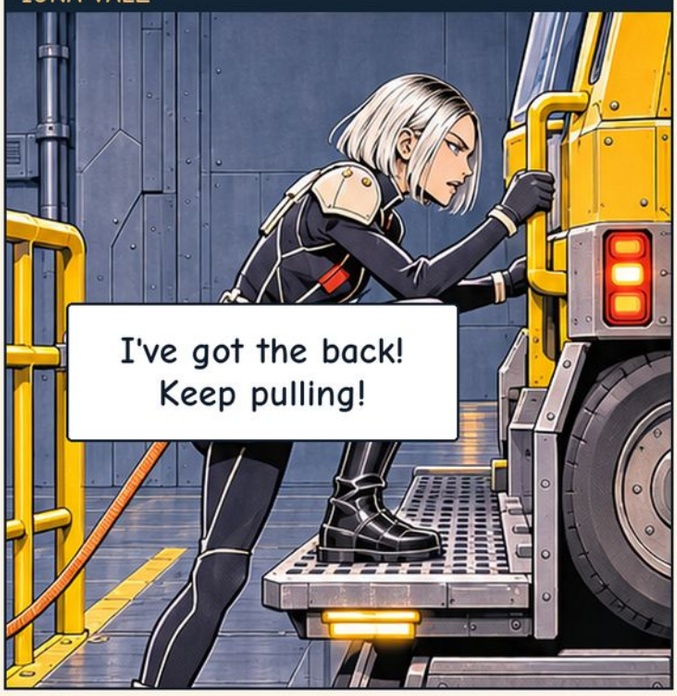
PIP · LATER

Gate A's main catch was slipping out. Tavi's handwheel took the load for a moment so I could push it back.

TAVI ORR

PIP ARDEN

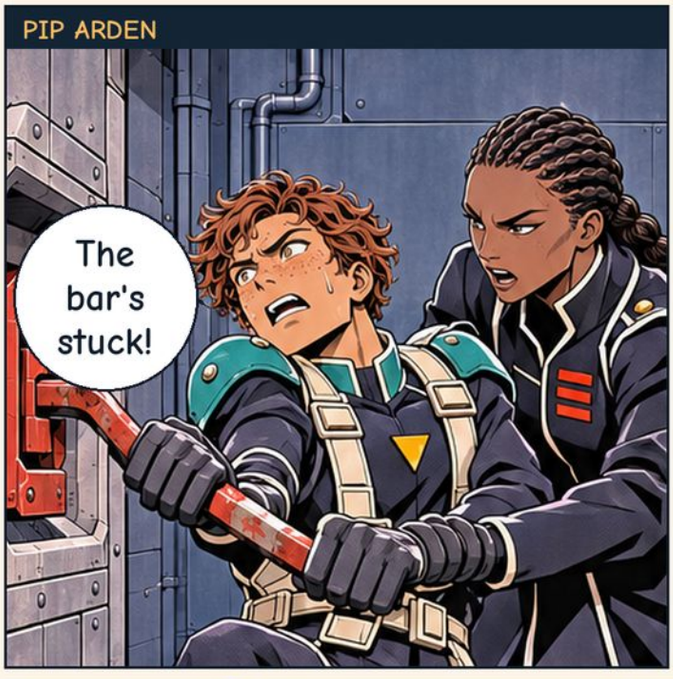
IONA VALE

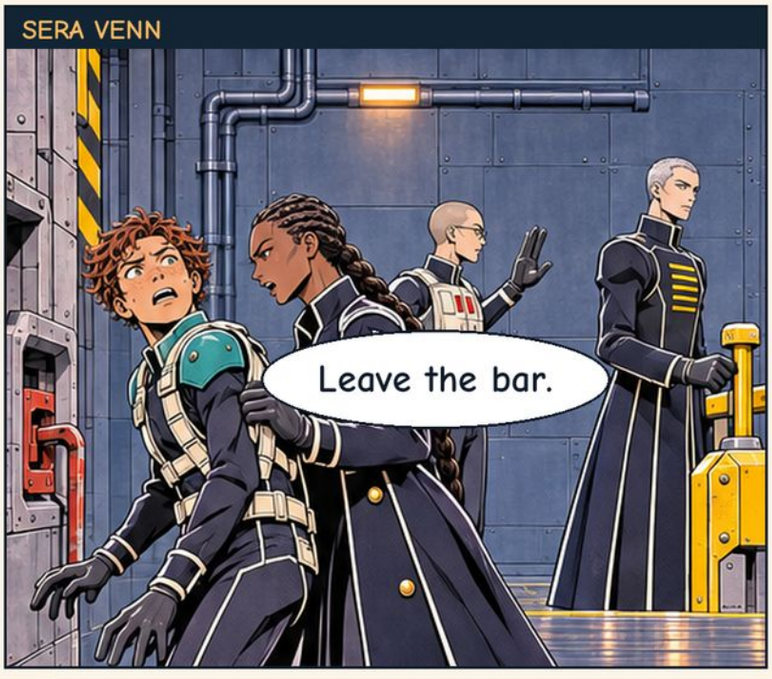


SERA VENN

PIP · LATER

The pod was through, but Iona's orange safety line still crossed the gate. Letting go now could trap her.





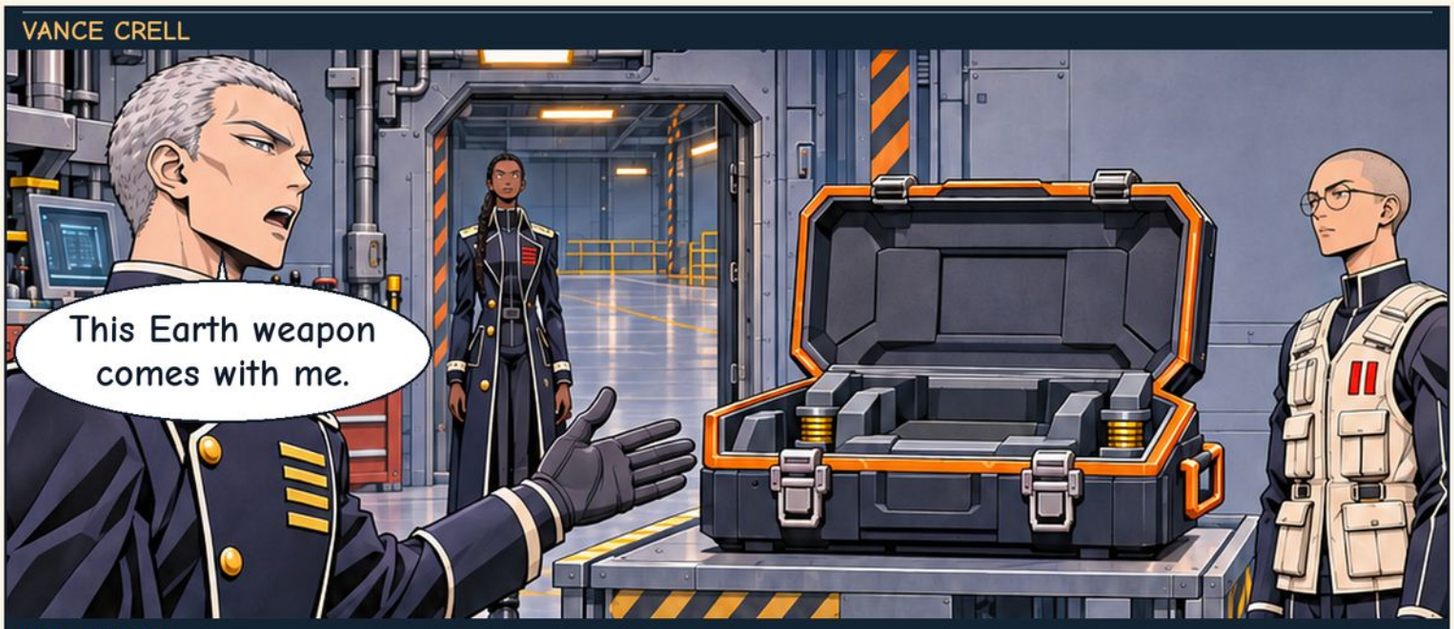
PIP · LATER

Crell released the backup. The catch kicked free when I let go; the bent bar stayed jammed. Gate A shut. Both my hands came home.

PIP ARDEN
I think I broke your crowbar.
SERA VENN
We'll get another.
SERA VENN
Twelve children. Two adults. All here.
SCHOOLGIRL
He was scared too.
IONA VALE
Yeah! And he stayed! That's our Pip!

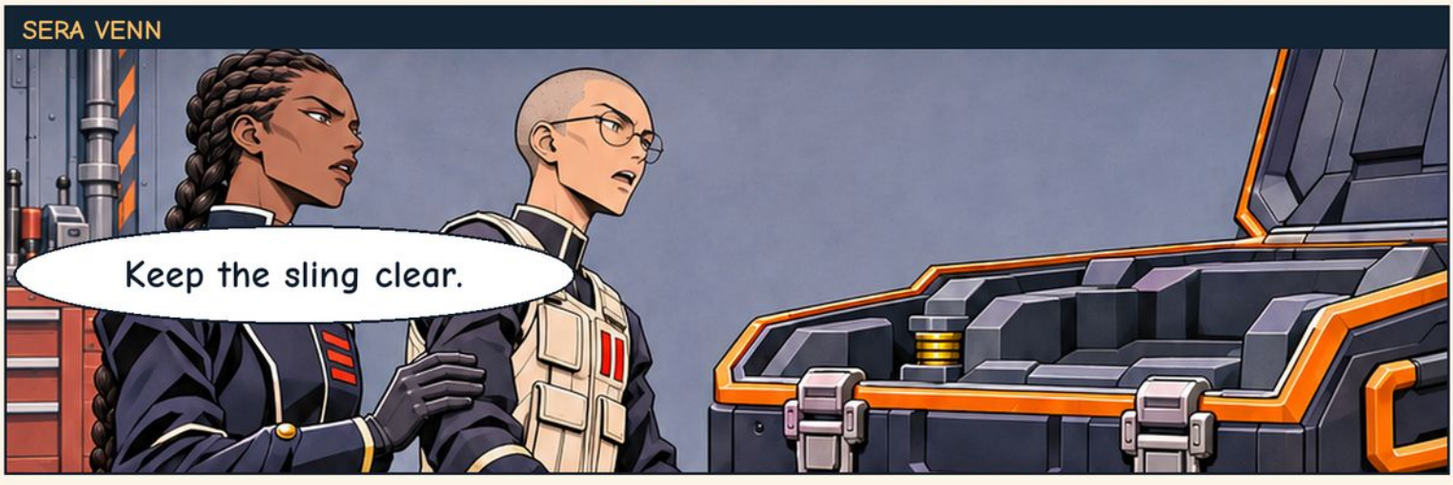
Best landing all month. Nobody got it.

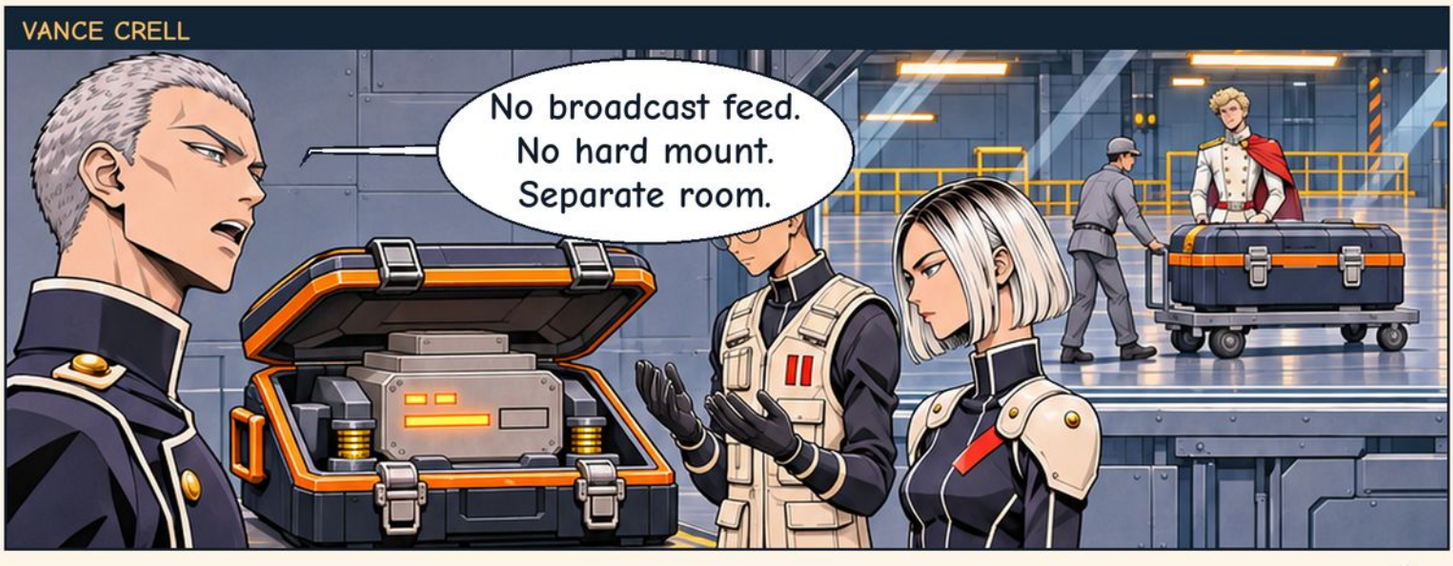
CAPTAIN BEAM
Everyone out? Oh, splendid. Splendid.
CAPTAIN BEAM
We have excellent coverage of the banner.
CAPTAIN BEAM
Mars saw our rescue team perform an unforgettable demonstration!
SCHOOLGIRL
Was the scary bit on purpose?
CAPTAIN BEAM
No. You were very brave.

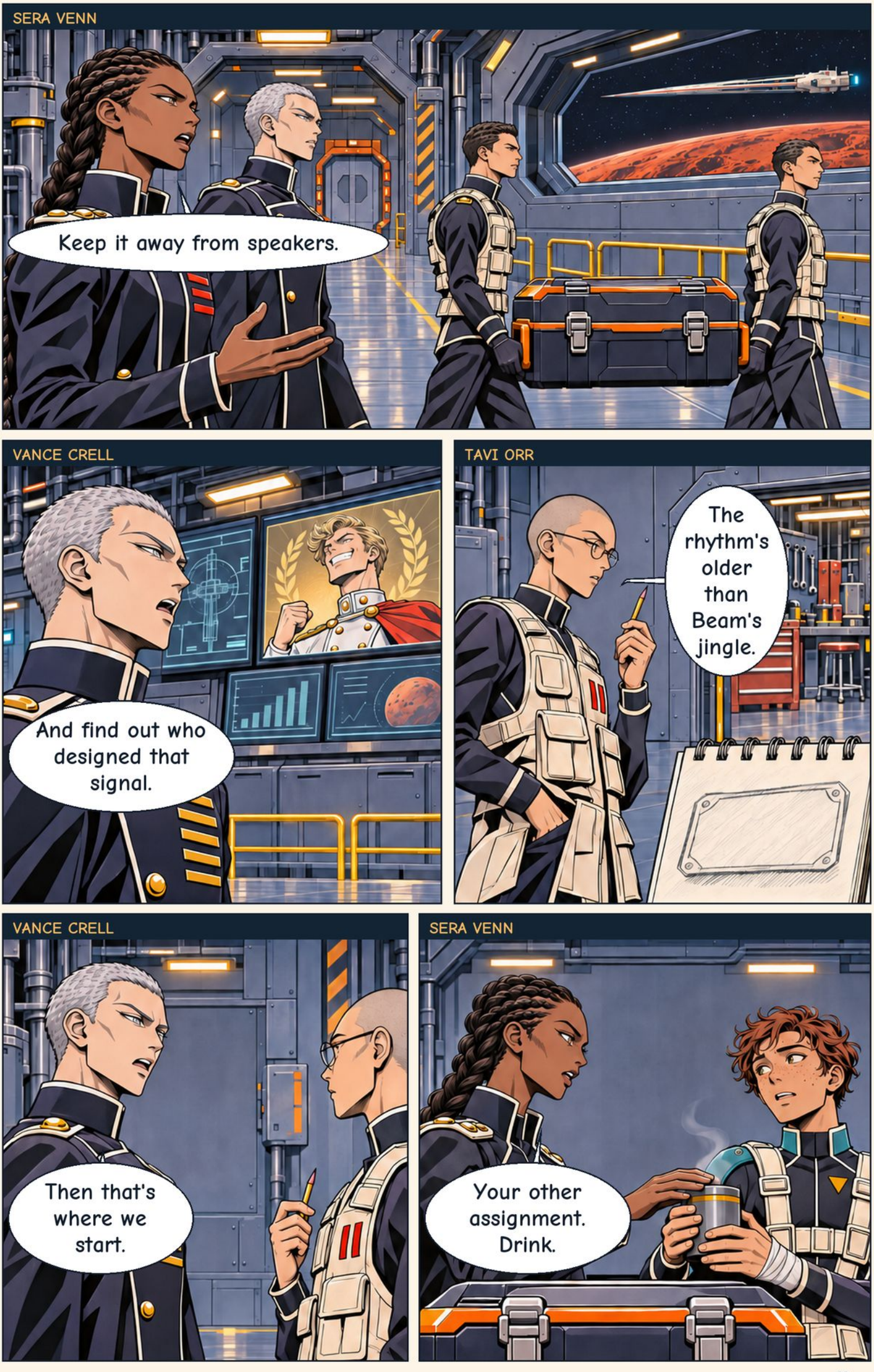


PIP · LATER

Crell called it an Earth weapon. We didn't know that. His padded transport case could finally keep it isolated.

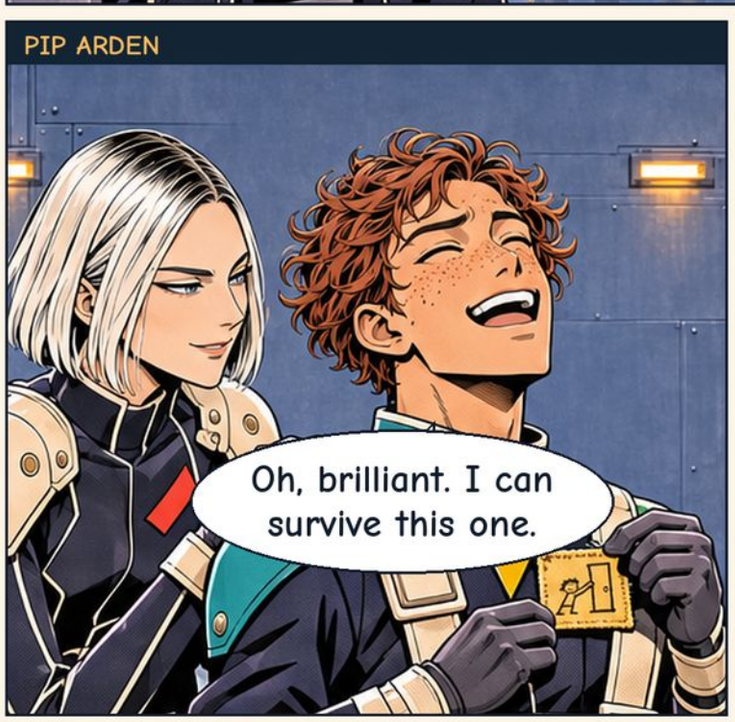





SERA VENN
Keep it away from speakers.
VANCE CRELL
And find out who designed that signal.
TAVI ORR
The rhythm's older than Beam's jingle.
VANCE CRELL
Then that's where we start.
SERA VENN
Your other assignment. Drink.

PIP · LATER

The children made me a medal from banner cloth. No trolley required. Rook looked ready to trade.

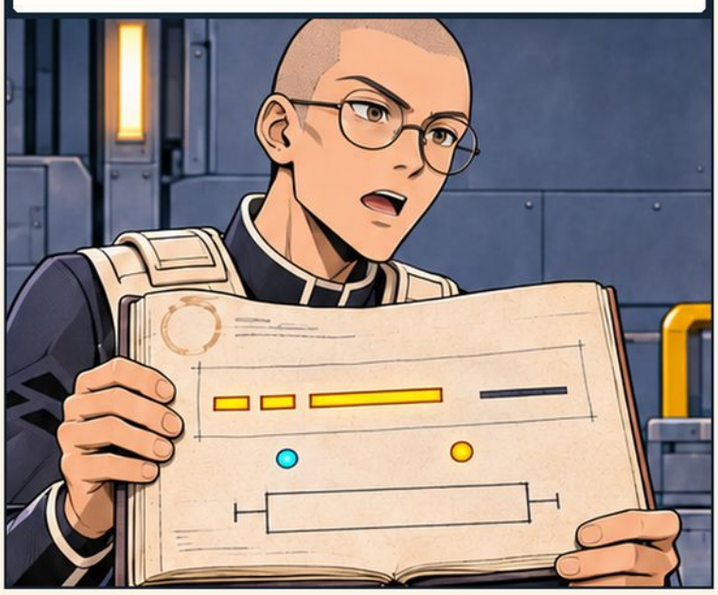


PIP ARDEN

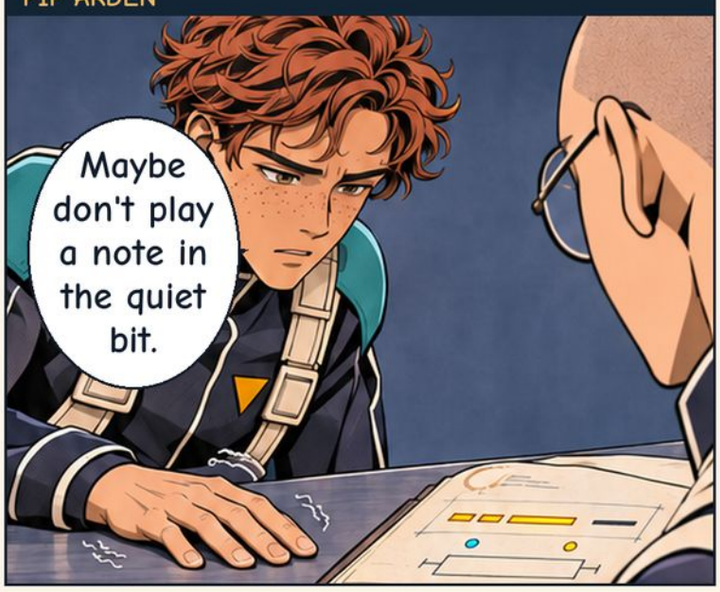
You saw something while I held the gate?

TAVI ORR

That blank comes after three marks. Like the silent beat.



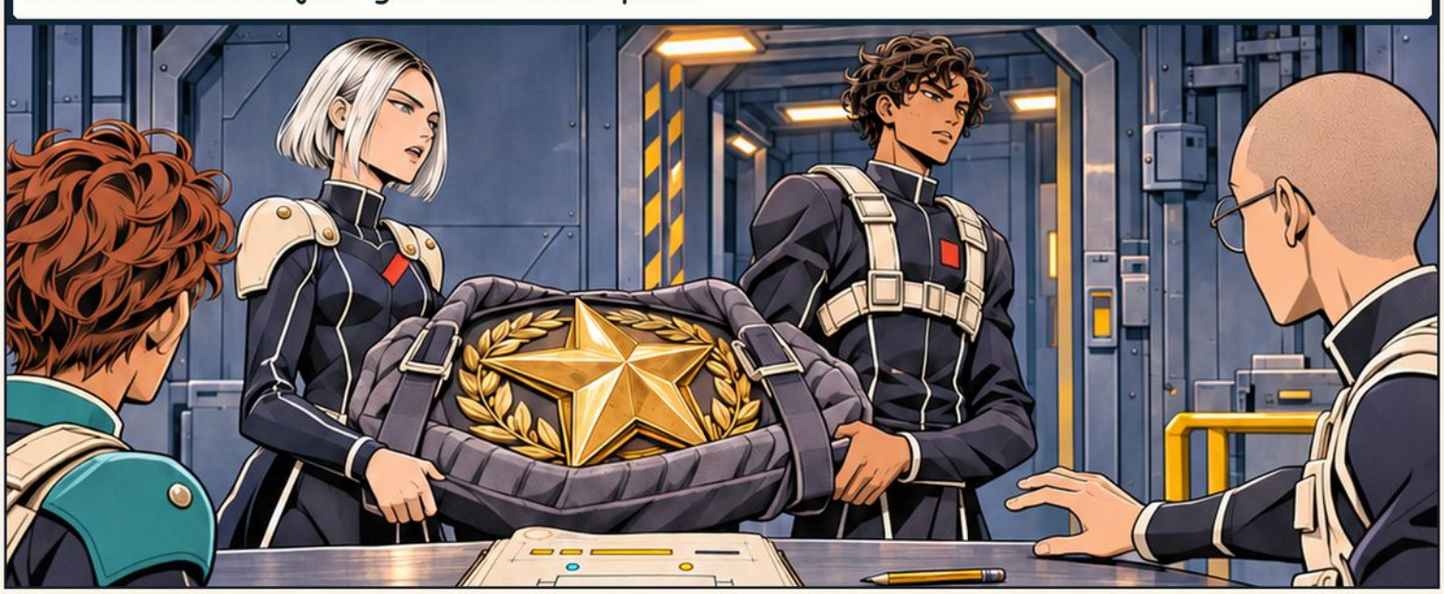
PIP ARDEN



TAVI ORR

IONA VALE

Not here! We've just got this room quiet!

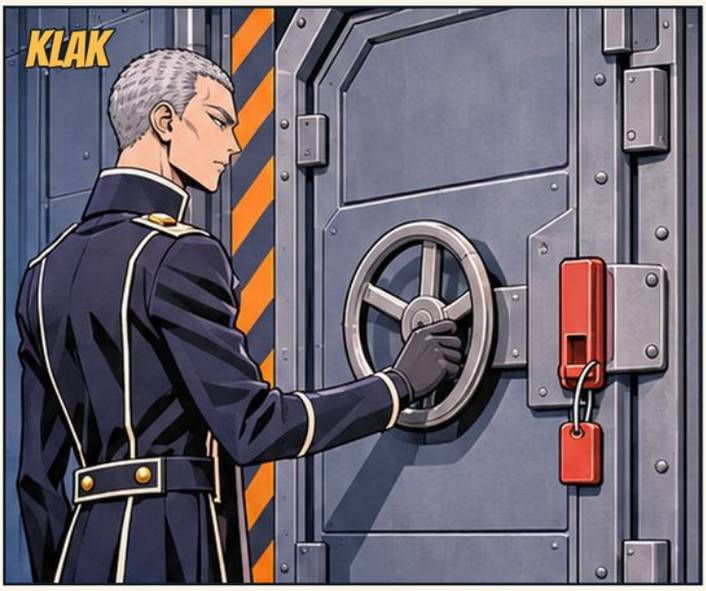


PIP · LATER

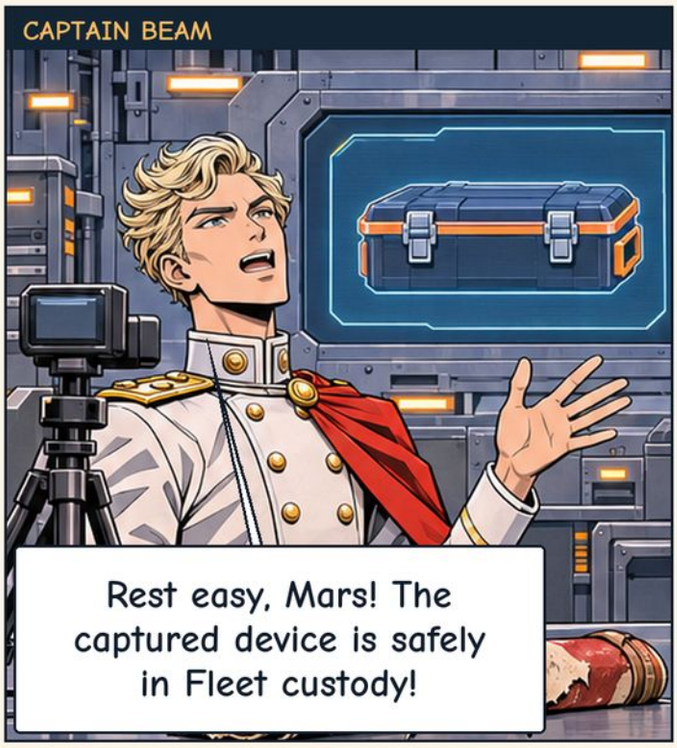
Crell put the occupied case in the dock's secure room until his ship could take it. We saw the core inside.

VANCE CRELL

SERA VENN



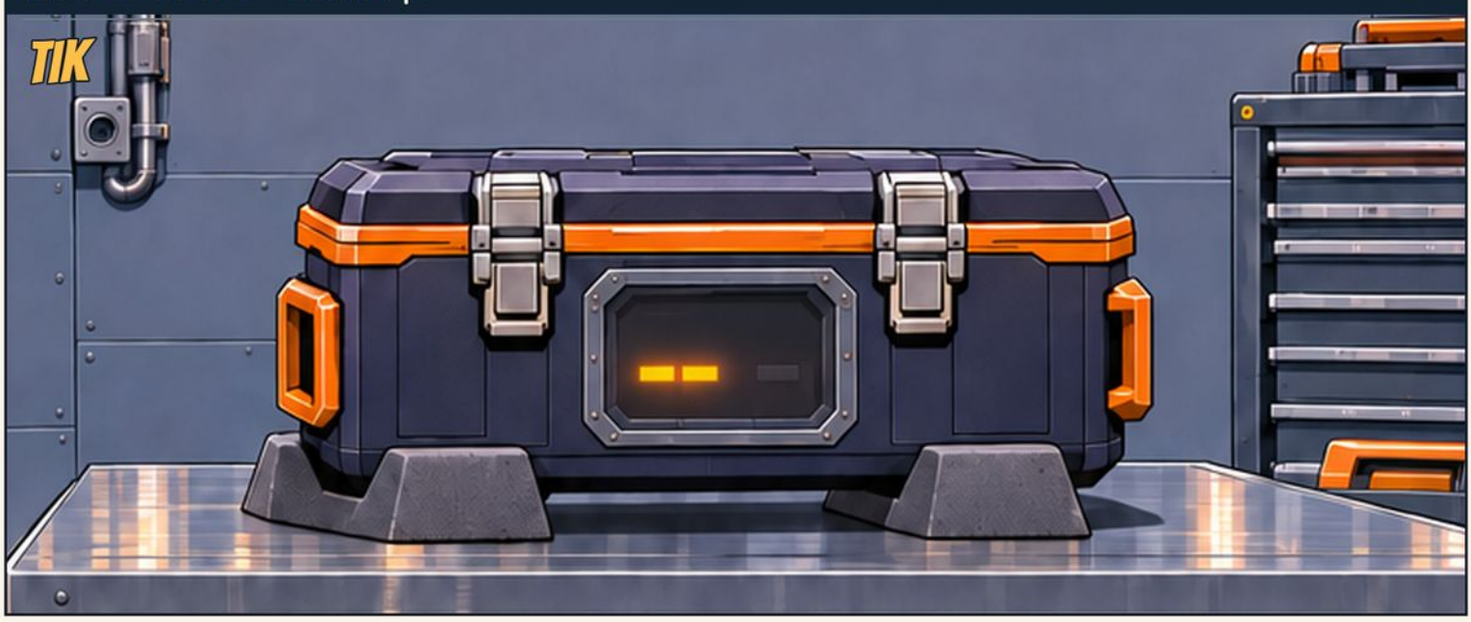
CAPTAIN BEAM

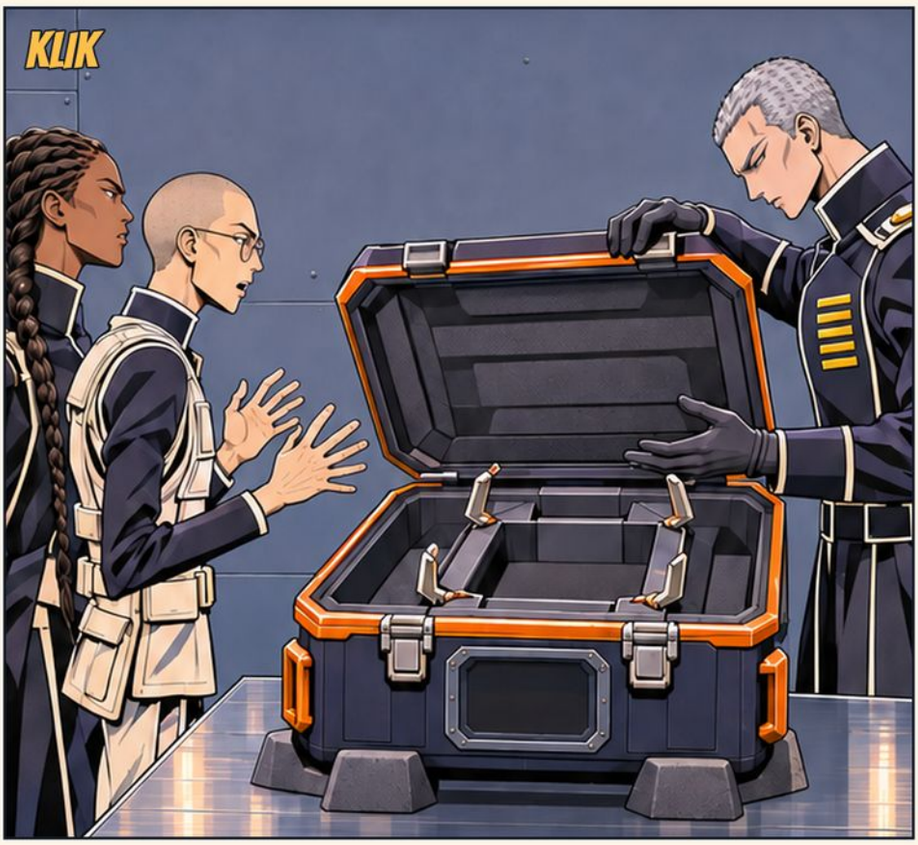


TAVI ORR

PIP · LATER

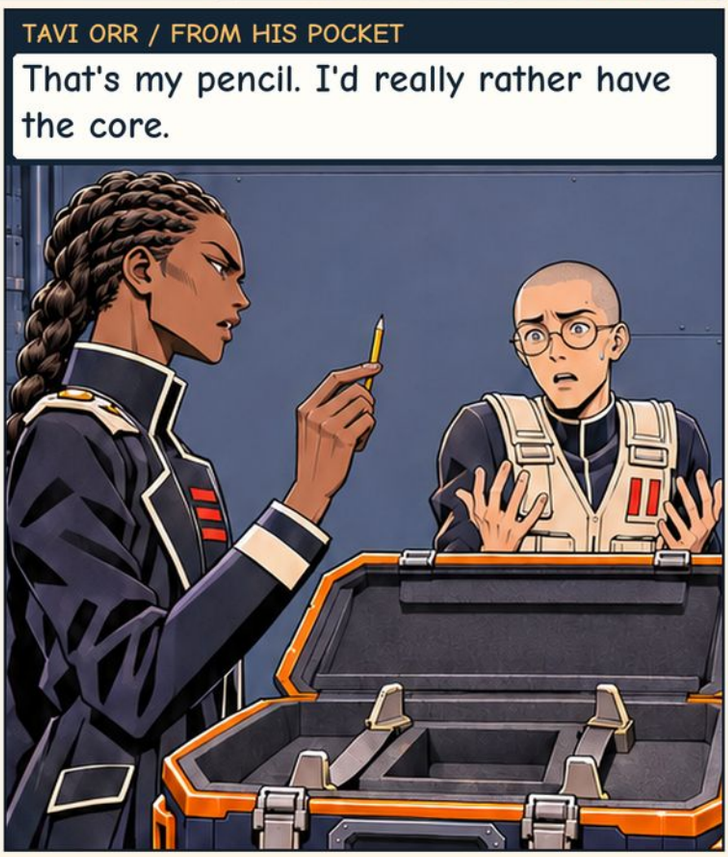
Later that night, Crell returned for the case. The room was still sealed. Tavi was with us in the workshop.





SERA VENN
Where's the core?

VANCE CRELL
Tavi Orr?


TAVI ORR / FROM HIS POCKET
That's my pencil. I'd really rather have the core.

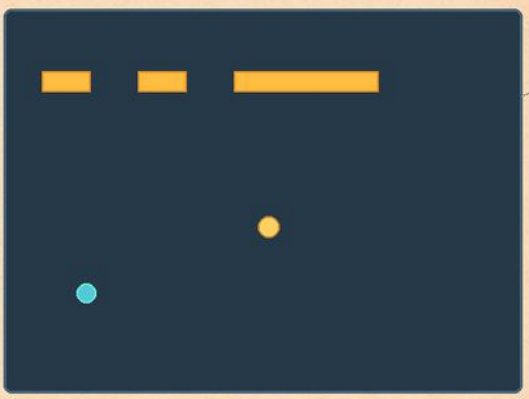
ROOK SEN
So it's definitely not an authorised souvenir.

SERA VENN
Boots on. Find it.

IONA VALE
Come on! It can't have gone far!
PIP ARDEN
Hang on. Did you hear—
VOLUME 3 · AGAIN.
TIK
We'd saved the children, but the core had vanished from Crell's locked room.
Nobody ever asks about the crowbar.
NIGHT SHIFT

HANDBOOK?

01



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